Diamond in The Rough

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by Anonymous

Notes

So:
I'm too lazy for chapter titles, barely managed to name this fic
I researched a bit and turns out these two (Casta and SW) had actual freaking logical names, I'm running with them.
And I guess I just had this wild idea and needed to share it…

Anyways, ladies, gents, and non-binary folks, enjoy.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> The beginning of this chapter is basically a filter, if u get past it, you can read the whole thing hah
>
> Ok, no, there isn't much more like the initial scenes, but well, it kinda still is a filter. Remember, this is an M-rated fic, alright?

It was a rainy night in the surface world under the floating island of Mystacor. Light Spinner arrived at a brothel, protecting herself from the downpour, and walked in with a solemnity characteristic of her.

There she was: the woman she had been looking for. According to her sources, she went by the name ‘Castaspella’, had been working there for quite a few years now, and was about twenty-five years old.

This particular place had a bar and some tables at the front, while the back consisted of several rooms, both to be used and to observe those using it.

What a place…

Light Spinner thought it would take her a while to find her in such a concurred establishment, but that night she was in luck. The woman was comfortably sitting at the bar, seemingly waiting for someone, dressed in a short blue dress. Far from shy, the sorceress approached and sat next to her.

“Good evening” she said, calling Castaspella’s attention.

“Evening” the woman replied, letting out half a smile, and looking her over as Light Spinner ordered a coffee. “What brings someone so… important like you to the surface?”

“I see you can recognize someone from Mystacor pretty easily” she noticed. “Have you ever been there?”

“Me!?” she asked before laughing loudly. “Of course not!”

“Well… This could be your lucky day” the sorceress said, right as her coffee was brought. “I want you to come with me” she told her.

“I’m sorry, but, who are you?”

“I can’t tell you much, but I’ve been looking for you”.

“Why?”

“Because I think you have the potential to become quite a proficient sorceress” Light Spinner explained.

“I don’t…”

“My sources tell me you *do* use magic occasionally” she interrupted. “And I believe that’s only the beginning for someone like you”.

“Look, I only have a while before a client arrives, so if you just want to chat with me, I’ll let you do it for free this time. But normally, my time is valuable, so next time you better pay…” Castaspella stated.

“I see” she sighed. “But you wanted to know what brings me here, and the truth is I’m *very* interested in you and the potential you have” the sorceress insisted.

“You keep repeating that, but there’s no way someone like *me* can be a ‘proficient sorceress’ at all. Not only because I’m just a surface dweller, but also because people like me are considered the lowest of the low by you all up there” Castaspella argued. “Are we not?”

“That much is true, but not for me” Light Spinner assured her. “I don’t care what the others think, I trust my sources and had to come to take a look at you personally”.

“Well, this is what there is to me. Not much else” the woman said. “Unless you’d like to see what I’m *really* proficient at” she proposed, smirking. “Watching is free”.

“What if I do?” Light Spinner asked, smirking back at her.

“In that case, I hope you enjoy the show” she laughed, right before someone called her attention. “Ah… I have to go now. My client has arrived” Castaspella noticed. “Now, you can come and watch, or leave… You know where the exit is”.

With that, the woman stood up from the bar, went to welcome her client, and took them to a room. Light Spinner followed and soon found the watching area where she could take a seat.

It was, in fact, quite a delight. The sorceress had to admit she was aroused and kept intently watching as Castaspella allowed her client to do what they wanted. Which wasn’t much…

They only fucked her for a few minutes before finishing, and then rested on the woman’s chest, seemingly about to pass out.

How pathetic.

However, it gave Light Spinner an idea. This was the world Castaspella knew. She had been too innocent to think she’d be able to easily convince her to leave it. No, she needed to ‘speak her language’. And now she knew how.

The sorceress stood up and knocked on the glass that separated both rooms, calling Castaspella’s attention.

“I see you stayed” the woman let out, smirking. With a smug look, she asked “Liked the show?”

“Much” Light Spinner replied. “In fact, I have a proposal”.

“Only if you’re willing to pay for my time” Castaspella reminded her.

“That’s exactly my intention” she assured her, raising a medium-sized bag obviously full of gold coins.

“Hear that?” the woman asked her client, trying to wake them up. “She wants to take your place” she told them, the implied statement obvious to them.

“But I have no more money” they mumbled.

“I will give you double your pay rate” Light Spinner insisted.

That was all she needed. Castaspella didn’t hesitate to call a pair of guards standing outside the door of her room, and they took away her drowsy client. Meanwhile, Light Spinner walked out of the watching area and joined the woman in her room.

“Double? Are you sure?” she asked, trying to figure out the scam.

“Double. For your time and for the proposal I mentioned” the sorceress replied.

“And what is your proposition?” Castaspella asked, watching her undress and set her robes aside.

“It shall be mutually beneficial” she assured her, approaching. Light Spinner didn’t lose a second and sat on Castaspella’s pelvis, then used some black tendrils of magic to fix her arms and legs, and leant forward, saying “I know exactly what you want, and what to do to please you”.

“Do you?”

“I do. And if I manage to make you cum, several times even, you’ll have to agree to go with me to Mystacor, to take a little test” she finally explained.

“So that’s your proposal? I see… Sounds interesting. I want to see you try” Castaspella laughed.

“And you will”.

The woman couldn’t recognize it, but Light Spinner was using black magic. It was a questionable kind of sorcery to use, but the sorceress didn’t care. In that place, there were no stuck-up sorcerers to judge her.

Her black tendrils felt like nothing Castaspella had ever experienced before, and Light Spinner could see that in her expression. The woman never imagined she'd like it so much.

Was it the way those tendrils perfectly fitted her insides? The slight heat they radiated? The strange yet delightful texture? Whatever it was, it managed to push her to ecstasy like never before.

That cursed stranger actually made it. So now, she had to agree to go with her.

"Fine" Castaspella sighed, panting. "I'll go… to your… silly island" she accepted, trying to recover her breath.

"Ah, but we were barely starting" Light Spinner told her, leaning over her again and speaking in hushed tones, only for her to hear. "I believe you want to top, but aren't usually allowed. Am I right?" she asked, brushing a finger down Castaspella's jaw.

The woman nodded weakly and let out a breathless laugh before telling her "My clients don't want me to do anything…"

"Then go ahead and show me what you want" she invited, helping her sit up.

"I… want you to turn around and lay down" she told her, still breathing with some difficulty.

As the sorceress complied, Castaspella comfortably sat over her, and *began*.

Light Spinner couldn't believe how pleasant it felt. The woman truly knew what she was doing, that much was clear to her. Her clients were fools for missing out on that. She enjoyed the feeling of Castaspella's body against hers for as long as the woman could move, until she got tired and withdrew.

"Exhausted already?" the sorceress asked.

"I can't move any more" Castaspella admitted. "Ah… you actually won the deal" she then sighed, closing her eyes.

She could feel Light Spinner move until she was laying with her, head resting on her chest, and the woman instinctively put her arms around her. The sorceress' hair felt so soft…

"I told you I knew what you wanted".

"How?"

"I could see how bored you looked. Your 'client' was terrible" Light Spinner laughed.

"I suppose I'll go with you or whatever…" Castaspella finally let out, burying her hands in the sorceress' hair. "But don't expect much".

"From whom I shan't expect much is from the council of fools that leads Mystacor. From you? I can, and do, expect a lot" she assured her.

“Well… I hope you return here even if our little excursion proves fruitless” the woman commented. “When are we going?”

“Tomorrow” Light Spinner replied, humming in pleasure as Castaspella caressed her hair. “And you don’t have to worry, I will pay your time so your bosses let you go” she added.

“Yes, that’s quite important, actually”.

“I figured” she assured her. “Now tell me…” the sorceress continued. “What do you know about your family?”

“Why the random question?”

“Just answer…”

“I didn’t meet my family. I was abandoned” she replied, looking away with a melancholic expression. “The owner of this place took me in… Former owner, actually. She’s already dead” she explained.

“I see…” Light Spinner sighed. “What a shame”.

“No need to pity me, I live well” she assured her. “I was raised pretty comfortably before having to work here” she added.

“Good to know…” the sorceress sighed. “And what about the sorcery you know?” she then inquired, lifting her head to look at Castaspella. She was still looking away and seemed unwilling to reply, so she insisted “I told you my sources mentioned it. You have been seen using defensive magic”.

“It’s nothing… Just some tricks I learnt from her” she finally admitted, looking back with a somewhat pained expression. “Unless your test tomorrow is on that kind of magic, I’ll sure disappoint you” she sighed.

“Defence magic is included, yes. But it’s not the only one. And it doesn’t matter if you haven’t learnt other kinds of sorcery, the test is only to show how much you do know, and how much you can catch on the fly when being taught” Light Spinner clarified.

Castaspella took a deep breath, eyes closed again, and slowly sighed. After a while of laying together, when both felt more recovered, the woman took her to the bathroom and both freshened up before putting their clothes back on. And then, once they arranged where to meet the next day and at what time, each went to their respective place.

However, they couldn’t sleep, no matter how drained they felt. Castaspella was too nervous about that test, and couldn’t help wondering why *she*, of all people, was being given this chance to go to the floating island. Light Spinner, on the other hand, was discussing with herself, thinking about what happened with the woman.

She couldn’t deny how much she enjoyed it, but if someone knew… Then what? It shouldn’t matter to anyone else. It’s often frowned upon to pay for sex, yes, but she didn’t have many options… And it’s not like she did anything illegal, either. Brothels are perfectly common in

the surface world, and many people frequent them. For the people working there, it's an honest job, and for their bosses, a business like any, in which they have to take care of their employees.

But now then… If her initial goal of returning Castaspella to her family succeeded, what would happen then?

She *wanted her* once more. And who knows if the woman would ever have sex with her again without paying for it?

Ugh, she couldn't seriously be dwelling on this…

Light Spinner brushed her face with both hands, got up from bed, and went for a cup of wine. Her lust was getting the best of her, so she needed to drown her thoughts immediately.

The next day, as promised, Castaspella met the sorceress in a coffee shop to have breakfast before going all the way up to Mystacor, and there they discussed a few things.

"I see you chose a longer dress for this trip" Light Spinner noticed.

"I figured you people up there wouldn't like my shorter options… Your robes really cover you from head to toe" the woman pointed out. "Including the face in your case" she added, gesturing at her veil. "I didn't want to say anything last night when you didn't take it off" she added.

After carefully sipping her coffee under the veil, Light Spinner nodded and admitted "I don't like it when people question me for it, so I appreciate your discretion".

"And- Sorry, I just realised… I don't know your name" Castaspella suddenly said, surprised that something so simple had escaped her mind. "I'm…"

"I know both your names" the sorceress interrupted. "Your real name, is 'Esmeralda', am I right?" she began. The woman nodded, but didn't say a word. "And your professional name… 'Castaspella'" she continued. "It has a nice ring. Even those fools up there would like it" she commented. "My name, my real name, is 'Beatrix'" she then said, extending her hand for Castaspella to shake. "But in Mystacor I'm known as 'Light Spinner'".

"That's an interesting choice of alias" the woman commented, smiling a bit. "Why do you have… different names?"

"Tradition".

"Really?"

"Absolutely" Light Spinner assured her, grabbing a bite of food. After swallowing, she explained "Now. The test consists of a theoretical part and a practical part. You will be given some material, about which you'll have to answer a few questions, and then you will have to put into practice that same knowledge. Is that clear?"

“Yeah… I get it” Castaspella nodded, putting down her cup of coffee. “What I don’t understand is the… purpose of that test” she clarified.

“It is aimed at demonstrating your potential. It will prove you’re fit to be a sorceress” Light Spinner replied. “Those fools never believed me when I said there are people like you down here, but I will show them how wrong they are” she added, noticeably angry.

Both ate in silence for a moment until Castaspella asked “So it’s all to prove a point?”

“That's what I get from this. But it’s not all there is to it. I also intend to help you. By learning sorcery, your life is bound to improve” she replied. “I believe it’s your birthright for someone like you” she insisted.

“My… birthright?” the woman replied. “Is there something you aren’t telling me?”

“Yes, but not now. Finish eating, we have to leave” Light Spinner cut her, waving at a waiter to pay the bill.

A few hours later, Castaspella walked out of the council room of Mystacor, where she had taken the famous test. While waiting, she reflected on how it had been easy for her to understand the material and reply to all the questions, and how she seemed to surprise the councillors when she had to perform the defence spells; she even told them she had needed such magic quite a lot in her life. But the rest? Ugh… she didn’t need them to tell her how pathetic that was.

She was deep in thought when a sorcerer walked into the corridor, completely unaware of her presence until he walked past her. The man stared for a long moment, seemingly in shock, until Castaspella noticed.

So when she shook her head at him, like questioning what he wanted, he couldn’t help saying “Esmeralda?”

He was calling her *real name*!?

Oh, it only angered her…

“It is ‘Castaspella’ for guys like you” she retorted, confusing the sorcerer.

“What…” he began, but got cut short by Light Spinner suddenly leaving the council room, fuming.

“We’re leaving” she said, grabbing Castaspella by the arm. She followed her without resisting and heard her mutter “They are just a bunch of fools”.

Behind them, the sorcerer remained shocked, and could only stare as they walked away.

The trip back to the surface was silent. The woman wasn't sure what to say, seeing Light Spinner so angry, and only took her hand, trying to soothe her. They only spoke once they were at Castaspella's flat.

"Come in" she invited. "I'll make some tea, if you want…"

"Much obliged" the sorceress thanked her.

Soon, they were sitting at a small table, each with a steamy cup, silent again until Castaspella spoke up.

"So… Will you tell me what happened back there?"

"The council… said you won't be accepted at Mystacor" she told her.

"I imagined" she sighed, looking away with half a smile.

"You don't understand" Light Spinner began, putting down her cup. "I think I know who you are. Who your family is. At least your brother. I know him" she explained. "The man you were talking to, that was him. He must have recognized you".

What!?

Castaspella had to force herself to swallow her tea and put down her cup with a loud clank before interrupting her "Woah, woah. Slow down. I absolutely don't care. I do *not* need my family. I don't need anything that island can offer, because apparently, I'm not skilled enough for them. So I would rather return to my job, no matter how dirty those fools think it is…"

Light Spinner lowered her head, let out a smirk, and said "I have to agree with a part of that".

"Then do me a favour and forget about me, about 'returning me to my family', or whatever plans you had" Castaspella requested.

"I would rather pay for you, to have you every day, all day, and use the time to train you" the sorceress countered. "Be it to prove those fools wrong, or just to prove it to you that you're more capable than you think" she admitted.

"You would…"

"I would" she interrupted before the woman could finish her question. "And if you don't mind, I'll arrange that tonight".

"What!?"

"I have the means. I'll make it happen" she insisted.

"You don't take a 'no' for an answer, do you?"

"Smart".

“But I’m not going back to that island. If you really want to train me, then do it here” Castaspella sentenced.

“As you wish… I’ll find a place to stay in the meantime” she accepted.

“And, I… should still work some… I only keep the… tips” the woman explained. “The actual money charged for me goes to my boss”.

“I see” Light Spinner sighed. “But only if it doesn’t affect your training” she clarified.

“I-it won’t” she assured her.

And the sorceress did as promised.

She first paid for a month in advance, allowing her to have Castaspella from morning until mid-afternoon, and trained her to the best of her capacities.

Yes, they would occasionally have a rest, enjoy some time together, but mostly, they spent the time reading and practising. Light Spinner had forgotten how much she enjoyed teaching someone, so the days with Castaspella quickly became the best of her year.

But that wasn’t all.

After that month, the sorceress couldn’t keep denying the attraction she felt; it was no longer mere lust… Just her luck.

During the last week, she agonized about it, sure the woman wouldn’t ever like her back, and could no longer bear having sex with her. Not like that.

“We need to stop” she told her, when Castaspella tried to drag her to the bed. “I can’t keep doing this with you”.

“What? Why not?” she asked, her tone disappointed.

“I don’t- I can’t- I *refuse* to pay for having sex with you. I only pay to train you. That’s it” she replied, turning around, seemingly angry.

“Did I do something to disappoint you? Am I- Am I not good enough?”

“Nonsense” the sorceress immediately denied, turning around again to hold her hands. “It’s nothing of the like. Understood? You’re more than good enough, Esmeralda. That’s why you don’t deserve to be… living like this! Being paid for sex with people who don’t… *feel* anything for you” she exploded.

“Be-Beatrix… You know… I don’t mind. It’s just a job” she reminded her, although it shocked her greatly. “Why are you suddenly like this?”

“Because… Ugh… I care for you more than you think” she finally admitted, closing her hands in fists as she got angry at herself. She felt so stupid for saying this. “Forget it…”

She felt like she had fucked up. That was it. But when the sorceress attempted to leave, Castaspella held her by the wrist.

“Please don’t go” she pleaded. “Come here” she then requested. Reaching for Light Spinner’s veil, she asked “May I?” When the sorceress nodded, she carefully took off the veil and cupped her cheek. “You really mean it? What you just said?”

“Every word” she admitted, leaning onto her touch.

“That’s a relief… I felt so stupid for… having fallen for you” Castaspella told her, smiling gently.

“You what!?” the sorceress exclaimed.

“Sorry I didn’t mention it before” she apologized before leaning forward, tiptoeing to reach Light Spinner’s face.

And so they kissed.

The sorceress embraced Castaspella tightly, kissing her back desperately, and refused to let go. Meanwhile, the woman held Light Spinner’s face with both hands and smiled as she continued to kiss her, caressing her cheeks with her thumbs.

By the time they finally broke the kiss, both were panting, and laughing, and hugging.

“I’m so grateful for finding you… I’m so *lucky* to have found you” Light Spinner sighed. “You have no idea”.

“I should be saying that” Castaspella laughed. “Now we should… perhaps have dinner. What do you say?” she proposed.

“You won’t go to work tonight?”

“No. I rather stay this time” she replied.

That night, the women enjoyed their time together like never before. Now, it was softer, gentler, and felt completely different from how it used to be. They re-explored each other’s bodies like it was the first time again, and shared all the kisses they couldn’t share before. It was… their night.

The next morning, as they had breakfast at Castaspella’s flat, the women discussed what they would do from then on.

“I mean it. I know it’s small but… I think it’s enough for us two. And you wouldn’t have to keep paying for that hotel you’re staying at” she told Light Spinner, before taking a bite of her food.

“I suppose you’re right, but in that case, you better allow me to pay for the expenses” she replied.

“No, no, no. Forget about it. It’s enough with you paying for my time” Castaspella refused.

“Except that now I have a different plan” Light Spinner told her, surprising the woman. “If I move in… Would you leave the brothel?”

“Leave… But… I can’t” she denied, shaking her head and looking down. “I’m sorry. You know I can’t”.

“If it’s because it’s your job, I can maintain you until you find a new one” the sorceress proposed.

“It’s not that… It’s because I have to pay what I owe for the years I was maintained”.

“And how much is that?”

“A lot”.

“Give me a number” Light Spinner insisted.

“I don’t really know…” she finally admitted.

“If the original owner who took care of you is dead… who is the manager now?” the sorceress asked.

“Her son” Castaspella told her, taking another bite of her food which she had almost forgotten.

“Do you know him?”

“Not personally, no”.

“Well… I will” she sentenced, smirking.

“What will you do!?”

“You’ll soon know…”

That afternoon, Light Spinner was being expected at the brothel to arrange the payment of another month. However, when she arrived, the woman didn’t hesitate to intimidate the guards into getting her a meeting with their boss. It took her a while, but she finally managed it…

He was a young man, dressed quite formally, and far more educated than Light Spinner expected. A real businessman despite his young age. So the matter was arranged within hours. The next day, the sorceress would transfer him all the money he considered Castaspella owed them, and the woman would be free from her debt…

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Sorry it took me so long to update.

Now:
In case you were curious and wanted to know more about Micah's role in this whole thing… welcome to this chapter.

There will be more, of course, but you can take this one as an introduction to their siblinghood, so to speak…

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time passed by. Castaspella kept training and studying sorcery, little by little becoming better at all kinds of magic, and took a part-time job at the coffee store she and Light Spinner frequented. That way, she had some income and could pay for half the expenses of her flat instead of having the sorceress pay it all for her. This job wasn't as profitable as her old one, but it was enough and allowed her to be more in control of her life. She didn't have to give almost all her earnings to anyone and, what's more important, she didn't have to deal with some of the obnoxious frequent clients she used to have.

She never felt ashamed of her job, always jumped to defend herself and her coworkers when they were called 'whores', and took pride in it, but it was true that she hadn't *chosen* her job. Now she had, and it felt rewarding.

"Today I served one of my old coworkers at the café" Castaspella told Light Spinner while they were having dinner. "Can you believe they all miss me? Not my boss, probably, but the guys and gals… yeah".

"Do you miss it?"

"The job? Not much. Especially not the worse clients I had; they were always the ones who went the most… But my coworkers? They are all good people, my friends, I do miss them…" she admitted.

"That's perfectly normal. But I recall the brothel has a bar at the front. Haven't you ever thought of going for a few drinks with them?" Light Spinner suggested.

"I don't know if I would be welcome there… Although I want to see them again, catch up… It would be nice" she replied, looking to the side and smiling faintly while swirling her cup of wine.

“I don’t see why you wouldn’t be well received there. But your reticence is understandable. Did you talk with the ex-coworker you met today?”

“Yes. When I had my break, I sat with her, and we talked for a while. Hopefully, she’ll tell the others I miss them too… And she was so surprised to know I was learning sorcery!”

“Really?” Light Spinner let out before sipping her wine. “What did she think?”

“She said most of them always thought I could be a great sorceress, had I been raised somewhere… better. So she was quite happy to know I’m doing well and progressing!”

“You look happy” she pointed out, smirking.

“I am, Bea! I…” Castaspella began, but got interrupted by a frantic knock on her door. “What? Who could it be at this time?” she wondered, standing up. “Or in general, who would come here?” the woman added, adjusting her night robe to cover her chest, as the knocking continued.

“Whoever it is, you better open soon, or they will kick down the door, Es” Light Spinner teasingly told her.

“Of course not. It has a defence spell on it. It’s tough as a brick wall” she assured her, but went for the doorknob regardless. Warily, she cracked the door open and took a look outside. She recognized him… “Aren’t you the sorcerer from Mystacor?” she realised.

“You remember me?”

“It was just a few months ago… And you were quite rude” she reproached him.

“Rude for calling your name!?” he exclaimed, indignant.

“You don’t know me! Why would you think suddenly calling a stranger by their first name out of the blue is alright!?”

“What else would I call you!? That’s your name!” he insisted.

“You *do not* know me! Aren’t you taught courtesy up there? If you’re approaching a stranger, at least say ‘hello’ first! If you had *asked me* my name, you would have known I don’t allow people like *you* to call me ‘Esmeralda’. So, yes! I found it rude!” she argued. “And what are you doing at my front door!? How did you know where I live!?”

“I wasn’t looking for you. I was looking for my mentor, Light Spinner” he clarified. “I-I’m sorry I didn’t… Whatever, I’m sorry. But I thought she was living here now. I was told she was staying at some hotel, but they said she hasn’t been there for months…” he explained, until he realised something and interrupted himself. In utter disbelief, he asked “Is she… living with you!?”

“That’s none of your business” she immediately replied, with a deadpan expression.

However, much to her annoyance, at that moment the sorceress yelled “Will you tell me who’s at the door!?”

“Let me in” the sorcerer demanded.

“No”.

“Let me in!” he insisted, now trying to force his way inside. “I know you’re there, Light Spinner!” he yelled, angry.

Castaspella stood her ground and kept him outside, ultimately using a spell to push him back, but she soon heard footsteps behind her, and looked back to see the sorceress join her at the door.

“What are you- Come on, Bea!” Castaspella criticized her, in hushed tones, noticing how loose her night robe was. “Why did you…”

“You’re sleeping with my sister!?” the sorcerer interrupted, crying out indignantly. It was too obvious… “How could you!?”

“How could I *what*, Micah?” the sorceress calmly asked back.

“Betray me!” he retorted.

“I did not betray you in any way…”

“You found my sister and took advantage of her!” he argued.

“She did not! You don’t know the first thing about me! So leave now, or I’ll make you!” Castaspella threatened, preparing a spell.

“You would attack your own brother?” he asked, with a sorrowful expression.

“I don’t know you. As far as I’m concerned, you’re an irritating stranger who interrupted my dinner with my *partner*” she replied, frowning.

“Partner!?” he repeated.

“Do I need to say it louder!?” Castaspella retorted, increasingly annoyed.

“This is… wrong” he finally said, pointing at her. “You have no idea what you’re saying” he added. “And, like it or not, you’re my sister, *my family*. I won’t just give up on you because you’re being stubborn” he sentenced.

“So after twenty-five years of forgetting I exist, you suddenly want me to welcome you with open arms? One hell of a brother you are… And a total asshole, no less” she insulted him.

“You repeat that I don’t know you, but you don’t know me either, yet you insult me!?”

“Why should I have any interest in meeting you after this scandal? And you *are* behaving like an ass right now, *Micah*!” Castaspella argued, pronouncing his name derisively.

Ah… It was impossible.

Micah shook his head and let out a resigned sigh. He gave up.

Without a word, he walked away, feeling defeated, and once he heard the door to the flat close, he stopped near a wall, supported himself on it, and let his tears fall.

He couldn’t believe it. That was his sister! After all those years, he found her… Since he saw her walking away with Light Spinner months ago, he waited for his mentor to take her back, to return her to him… But she never did.

How could he know Castaspella had refused to meet him?

No, he didn’t know. Instead, he thought it was all Light Spinner’s doing…

Back at the flat, it was past midnight when the women finally rested back on the bed, panting. They hadn’t spoken about the incident with Micah, Castaspella didn’t want to, but even now, her head was annoyingly going over the conversation.

Well…

She cursed internally before saying “I know I told you I didn’t want to talk about it, but I’m so… pissed still. What was all of that?”

“Your brother is a bit hot-headed” Light Spinner replied, eyes closed as she took deep breaths. Then, she sighed “I don’t know how he found me, however. That was unexpected, and I apologize”.

“No need. It wasn’t your fault” Castaspella let out, looking at the ceiling as she rested her head back on the pillow. “That people up there think they can do whatever they want… And while that also counts for you, at least you never forced my hand or tried to guilt-trip me as he did” she commented.

“I don’t think he meant it. But I see your point” Light Spinner said. “He was about twelve when you… were taken” she added. “Do you want to hear about that?” she asked, now looking back at her.

“In fact, no, I don’t. Not yet” Castaspella admitted. “If you don’t mind… I would rather we talk about that over breakfast tomorrow”.

“That may be difficult. We don’t have enough time before you go to work” the sorceress reminded her.

“What about lunch, then?”

“I suppose, yes” she agreed. “But don’t feel obligated to hear it all. If at any point you feel… uncomfortable, then we’ll simply retake the conversation later, alright?” she clarified, reaching out to cup her cheek. “I would have told you sooner, but you weren’t ready, I believe. I never meant to keep anything from you”.

“You did. You kept a lot. But I understand why, no need to worry…” Castaspella replied.

“I still think I should apologize, Es”.

“It’s alright, Bea” she insisted.

The next day, when the woman finished her shift at the café, she sat at a table to wait for Light Spinner. After a while, someone approached her but, much to her surprise, it wasn’t the sorceress. It was one of her old coworkers who had probably been told she now worked there and went to visit.

“Oh. My. Stars!” they exclaimed after greeting her. “Girl, I missed you! Drinking Night isn’t the same without you” they laughed. “Can I take a seat?”

“I’m waiting for someone, but until she arrives, it’s alright” Castaspella agreed.

“So, tell me about this sorceress who took you away from us” they requested, raising their brows, eyes shining with interest.

“Oh, my. It’s not such a big deal…”

“She paid off your debt, girl! That’s a *great* deal!” they argued. “And we’re talking about someone who comes all the way from Mystacor… So go ahead and share the tea”.

Castaspella couldn’t help laughing at the way they said it, but finally complied and said “Well… Apparently, she found me through some, I don’t know, spies she has or something, and kept tabs on me for a while before going to the brothel to meet me”.

“Mmm, a stalker?” they asked.

“A bit” she admitted, rolling her eyes. “But it was because she was convinced I had this… magical potential and wanted me to take a test at Mystacor. Which I did, but got rejected. So she’s been teaching me personally” she concluded.

“And how did this woman convince our dear Casta to take a random test up there?” they inquired, surprised.

“We made a deal… I won’t tell you much, but she fulfilled her end, so I had to go” she replied. “I mean, I was curious too but, like… I knew it wouldn’t work” she added. “I just wasn’t expecting her to have so much trust in me. But now I can’t deny she was right! I’ve been improving a lot!” she cheerfully told them.

“Girl, you look so happy. I’m jealous” they laughed.

Castaspella laughed with them and said “Oh, Stars. I missed you…”

At that same moment, their conversation was cut short by Light Spinner’s arrival. It was their former coworker who noticed her first and gave the woman a knowing look before standing up.

“I’m just leaving. Please don’t mind me…” they farewelled. “A pleasure catching up with you” they told Castaspella, and walked away to sit at an empty table.

“Friend of yours? An ex-coworker, I presume” Light Spinner let out as she took a seat.

“Yes, they… wanted to see how I’m doing…”

“I see. Shall we order something before we begin?” she asked, taking a look at the menu.

“Oh, of course. I recommend the speciality” Castaspella replied, smiling happily.

“Gladly”

The women ordered right away and, while waiting for their food, began the difficult conversation.

“You said I was taken… I thought I had been abandoned. What else am I wrong about?” Castaspella asked.

“First answer me something” Light Spinner requested. “The name of your late boss?”

“I-it was… She had me call her ‘Zo’” she hesitantly replied. “And before you ask, I’m guessing where this is going… Yes, she was the one who taught me defence magic” she added.

“That was my next question… So, go ahead and take a wild guess” the sorceress offered.

“Was she from Mystacor? Did she ‘take me’ from there?” Castaspella asked, fearing her reply.

“Clever…” she uttered. Light Spinner took a deep breath and sighed, expression severe. “Yes, indeed. More than fifteen years ago” she went on. “She was a tutor, an excellent one. We don’t know what happened, but one day she left Mystacor for good. I found out what she was doing, but I also realised it made no sense to… tell on her. It had been her decision to leave, after all…” the sorceress explained.

“Did you know about me?”

“No. I was a young tutor still, that information was out of my reach, and my web of spies wasn’t nearly as developed as it is now” she explained. “I only learnt about you upon becoming a member of the council, and thanks to Micah I could identify you. After all, you do look very alike… Or, you did before he grew that beard” she continued, laughing a bit at the end.

“And why did he say you betrayed him?”

“Because I told him years ago I would find you” she replied, serious. That moment, the food arrived, so she waited until the waiter left before continuing “I never promised to ‘return you to him’ or anything similar. I only said I would try to take you back to the island, which I actually couldn’t do because the council rejected you. And, of course, had you refused to stay in Mystacor, it would be out of my hands”.

“So he… suddenly decided to look for me months after seeing me there?” Castaspella asked, incredulous. “If he was so interested in me, why didn’t he try to contact you earlier?” she continued. “And now he’s acting like *you* took me away” she added, rather furious.

Light Spinner let out a sigh as the woman indignantly huffed and watched her angrily eat for a moment.

She understood, but it felt wrong to leave her with that view of him.

“Look, Micah is a good man” she began. “He’s out of his mind right now, but it’s clearly because of how much he waited to find you” she explained. “And realising I never spoke to you about him… Well, of course he’s angry” she admitted. “I never told you a thing about him because you didn’t want to know, but perhaps I should have spoken to him…”

Castaspella immediately shook her head, humming in denial.

“Forget that. There’s no excuse for his behaviour” she complained. “Besides, if he reacted like that to us having a relationship, how do you think he’ll respond if he ever learns I used to work at a brothel!?” she added, even more indignant. “The man acts as if he had any right to dictate my life, as if he ‘knew what’s best for me’ or something, a-as if I were his ‘baby sister’, but that’s bullshit! He has shown little interest in actually getting to know me, and instead tried to force his way into my… Not even into my life, into my *flat*!” she continued. “How can he expect me to… to…” Castaspella went on, but quickly trailed off.

“Es?” Light Spinner called her.

“He’s there” she uttered. “What is he doing?” she wondered, watching him just stand in the middle of the street, looking into the café. “He’s just staring” she told her, swallowing nervously.

“He can’t do anything, alright? I won’t let him get closer” Light Spinner promised, grabbing one of her hands reassuringly.

But it was unnecessary. The women continued eating, and he simply stared for a whole hour before leaving. They never knew what he was doing there, but they didn’t see him again for a while after that.

A few weeks went by since the incident with Micah, and Light Spinner ordered her spies to keep tabs on him. What she learnt was that he had returned to Mystacor, confronted the

council about her actions, yet managed nothing as the council wasn't interested. They were certainly *pleased* with Light Spinner's absence and, as they had already rejected Castaspella, there was simply no reason to do anything about the matter.

Micah was left alone.

The spies reported he spent many days locked in his room, seemingly doing nothing. After weeks, he reappeared, and it surprised Light Spinner to learn he was once again visiting the surface. As expected, it didn't take long for him to contact her, and both met at a bar during Castaspella's shift.

"I'll be clear. I'm meeting you now, but you're not allowed to get close to your sister unless she agrees. You can't go to the café, or the flat. Is that clear?"

"Yes, yes" he reluctantly agreed. "For now I need to talk to you" he clarified. "I want to know why- How- What happened? How did you two… end up together!?"

"I'd normally say that's none of your concern, but I'll make an exception" she decided. "I met her under certain circumstances that led to us getting closer than I would normally be with someone. And, after a month of teaching her, I realised I had developed… feelings for her. Which almost made me back down and leave her. But she returned those feelings. I never took advantage of her, that much I can promise" she told him.

"I still don't like it… At all…"

"I understand".

"And why didn't you tell her about me?"

"I wanted to, but she didn't want to hear it" she replied. "Did you expect me to force her to learn about things she utterly refused to know?"

Micah knew that condescending tone.

"No, I didn't" he uttered, resigned. He was *so* angry… "I just can't believe… any of this!" he insisted. "You knew she was my sister! How could you!?"

"She isn't *just* your sister, Micah!" she refuted. "She's a woman, first and foremost" she reminded him. "I refuse to acknowledge her as an extension of you, therefore I see nothing wrong with my relationship with her".

"My own mentor… with my little sister…" he lamented, holding his head between his hands.

A cold drink kept sweating in front of him as he never touched the glass, while Light Spinner calmly drank hers. She gave him a moment to compose himself, but he seemed too stressed.

"If you feel so aggravated by me, why are you *talking* with me?" she finally asked.

“I wanted answers” he replied, without looking back. “I’ve been… reflecting for so long… If my sister doesn’t want to meet me at all… what else can I do?”

“Give her time. Perhaps one day she will” the sorceress suggested. “For now, stay away, lest you piss her off again”.

“If you really love her, do something for me” he requested, stopping Light Spinner who was about to get up. “Tell her I’m sorry, and that I only want to be part of her life. Make up for the decades we lost”.

“I’ll tell her, but I can’t promise anything”.

“That’s enough”.

“Will you return to Mystacor?” she asked.

“Yes”.

“How’s that… *thing* going?”

“It’s… growing. And getting more dangerous” he replied, looking down and finally taking a sip from his glass.

“Have you been practising the defence spells I taught you?”

“Yes, I didn’t know what else to do” he admitted.

“That’s good” she nodded. “With any luck, your sister will be ready before we run out of time” she told him, smiling under the veil. “She’s exceedingly good at defence magic. You should see her” she commented, proud. “I’ll make sure she becomes the best sorceress to have stepped on the island. Her proficiency with defence spells is exactly what Mystacor needs now” she concluded.

“She’s that good?”

“More than you can imagine. She just needs to perfect a few things” she clarified.

This time, he only nodded and let the sorceress go. He spent a while at the bar until his drink was gone, and ordered a second one. By the time he finally left, it was nighttime, but he still returned to Mystacor safely, albeit drunk.

“Es, listen to me” Light Spinner said, following the woman with her sight as she walked around the room. “He is sorry. He told me to tell you…”

“I don’t care. I don’t want his apologies” Castaspella interrupted, refusing to hear her. “Sorry or not, I don’t want to hear about him, not for now”.

“Just know… that if you ever change your mind, he will be more than glad to meet you” she told her. “It’s been almost two decades, yes, but he still wants to be in your life”.

“I don’t!” the woman exclaimed, suddenly halting. “What will happen when he learns who I am!? Who I was!? Don’t you see I’m scared!?” she yelled.

Light Spinner didn’t reply. She simply approached Castaspella and hugged her.

“It’s alright, Es”.

“I’m sorry” she apologized. “But I can’t take this, Bea. Not now” she insisted, sobbing.

“I understand” Light Spinner assured her, caressing her hair. “And you have nothing to worry about. He promised to stay away”.

It was a sunny day. Sunlight came in through the windows of the flat where Castaspella was sitting, right in front of her brother. Next to her, Light Spinner stood on her feet, giving them enough space but offering Castaspella a sense of security.

“So you know you were taken from Mystacor?” Micah asked.

“Yes. I was told as much” she nodded. “I didn’t know that, I thought I had been abandoned. And I didn’t know about you either” she continued. After taking a deep breath, eyes closed for a second, she told him “I was raised by the woman who took me. She was… the owner of a brothel…”

“What? That- She opened a brothel after leaving the island!?” he exclaimed, bewildered.

“No, she already had it. She only abandoned Mystacor to fully dedicate to it” Light Spinner clarified.

“And she taught me some magic even. Which came in handy, you know? The defence spells” Castaspella told him.

“How could that woman raise you there!? In a world of… of *prostitutes*!” he indignantly said, noticeably disgusted when he pronounced the last word.

“Micah!” Castaspella called out, slamming her hands on the table as she suddenly stood up.

“No, no! It’s just insane! Who raises a kid among *whores*!?” he insisted.

“Micah!” she yelled again, enraged. “Do not call them that! Don’t you dare disrespect the workers of the brothel!” she ordered. “We- They are all honest people!”

“What!? Don’t tell me you worked at that place!” he retorted, sickened at the mere thought of it.

“Yes, I did!” she finally exploded.

“You what!?” he exclaimed, standing up too. He approached her and said “Tell me that isn’t true”.

“It is, Micah” she assured him. “That people you speak about… they were my colleagues. They are still my friends… I may no longer work there, but I still take great offence when someone uses *that word* to refer to them” she told him, seething.

“What else would I call them!? They are *whores*! That’s what they are!” he yelled again, right before a resounding slap interrupted him.

Castaspella’s expression was dead serious after smacking him across the face with all her might, while he looked back in disbelief.

“Out of my home. Now” she ordered. “Now!” she insisted, seeing as he didn’t move.

“You heard her” Light Spinner said, approaching Micah to take him away.

“Out!” Castaspella cried, pointing at the door.

Light Spinner had to drag him to the door and push him outside, while Castaspella sat at the table again, sobbing.

“Es” the sorceress’ voice called her. “Es!” she insisted.

The woman struggled to open her eyes, realising she was panting and felt her throat dry. Next to her, Light Spinner was trying to wake her up, concerned.

“What happened?” she asked, her voice strained.

“You were… having a nightmare, maybe?” the sorceress said. “I heard you crying…”

“It was… yes” she nodded, starting to cry again.

“Easy there” Light Spinner let out, trying to soothe her as they both hugged. “Need to tell me about it?”

It took Castaspella a moment, but she finally sobbed “I had accepted meeting Micah. A-and he kept… He kept saying people who work at a brothel are ‘whores’ and-and I…”

“I understand” the sorceress interrupted, holding her tighter. “Just take a deep breath”.

“I slapped him” she cried.

“Es, it was just a nightmare” she reminded her. “It’s your fear of his reaction… Of what he will say” she told her. “You don’t know him and are afraid of him”.

“I don’t think I can meet him… ever” she kept sobbing.

“Give it time, Es” she suggested. “Give yourself time too” she added.

“I’ll… try” she finally agreed, taking a deep breath to calm down.

“Let’s go back to sleep now, alright?” Light Spinner invited.

“Yes, yes” Castaspella nodded.

She slowly lay down on the bed again, but this time rested closer to the sorceress, hugging her tightly. Light Spinner hugged her back, her expression softening, and caressed her hair until she was soundly asleep again. Meanwhile, she was left thinking… What if Micah *actually* behaved like that when, *or if*, he met her?

Chapter End Notes

Um, eh, just in case... The name "Zo" is a reference to a name I read on another fic, pay it no mind...

~~If you recognized it, no you did not~~

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

I particularly like this chapter
There's some insight into Casta's workplace, her friends, AND her relationship with Micah

I hope you like it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Bea, I have a question” Castaspella began, as they had breakfast together.

“Go ahead”.

“What does the council think about you using black magic? Or rather, do they know!?” she asked.

The woman wouldn’t say it, but she was thinking about the night they met and how she now understands those black tendrils the sorceress used to bind her were, in fact, black magic…

Light Spinner calmly sipped her tea, then replied “No, they don’t. They think I only *know* about black magic, the theory. Just like you do”.

“Then it means… if you tutored Micah, he also knows that?”

“Indeed. But he always refused to use it, if you’re curious”.

“I imagined” she admitted. “And also, how is it possible for you to use it without… getting corrupted?”

“Ah, clever question. You’re very observant” the sorceress praised her. “You see, I only control shadows at will, which is associated with black magic, but in its most innocuous form. As long as I don’t reach for more power, I will be fine” she assured her. “In any case, I would only resort to that if the situation was dire. It should be a matter of life and death”.

“Even if it kills you?” Castaspella questioned her, worried.

“I’m tougher than you think, but I guess it depends” she sighed. The sorceress extended her arm over the table and held one of her hands tightly. “But if it were for you, yes, even if it kills me”.

“Bea…” she lamented, raising her hand to kiss Light Spinner’s knuckles. “I understand you’re willing to die for me, but is it too much to ask you to *live* for me?” she asked. “It

sounds selfish, but I just don't want to lose you".

"I understand, Es. I promise, if I ever have to use it, I'll fight the black magic's corruption with everything I have so I can return to you".

"I'll take your word for it" Castaspella accepted, letting a tear fall down her cheek.

Light Spinner gently caressed her cheek to brush it away, and both returned to their breakfast.

"Don't worry now… With sorcerers like you around, I doubt I'd ever need to reach such an extreme" she assured her, sipping her tea again. "You, Es, are the key to finding safer ways to deal with all and any perils we might ever face" she insisted.

"Because of my defence magic?"

"Yes. But also because of your intelligence" she nodded. "You've been able to find alternative solutions to every challenge I've presented you with, something no one had managed to do before" she explained. "I knew those fools at the council were wrong…"

"Yes, yes. You're right, they are wrong. We all know" Castaspella mocked her, letting out a giggle.

"Laugh all you want. It's the truth" the sorceress retorted, which only made the woman laugh more.

Soon, they both finished eating and Castaspella rushed to work, only stopping a moment to kiss Light Spinner goodbye.

As months went by, Castaspella grew in knowledge and power, her spells improving each day, making Light Spinner proud. But she still missed her former coworkers. Perhaps she liked more her current life, yet the memory of them would usually make her nostalgic.

They were her friends and, occasionally, they would go for a coffee during her shift to at least say 'hello'. Many times they spoke about planning a reunion, going somewhere to eat together, but she almost gave up that idea as time passed and they never organized a thing.

Until two of them took it upon themselves to plan everything and quickly arranged a dinner at the same café where Castaspella worked. They promised to invite as many of their friends as possible, and settled the date for the following week.

The woman was thrilled! She returned to her flat overjoyed, and Light Spinner could see that. It amused her but, at first, she didn't want to say anything, lest she ruined her mood. Until curiosity got the best of her.

"I haven't seen you this cheerful in a while. Did something good happen?" she asked.

"Take a guess".

“Hmm… Related to your friends, maybe?”

“Yes!”

“Of course” the sorceress smiled. “You usually look very melancholic unless they visited you at work, did you know that?”

“Well… I’m not surprised” Castaspella admitted. “My current colleagues are horrible” she complained. “Except for the cook. But the other waiters?” she went on, before letting out a grunt. “There’s an idiot who asked if you were my *mom*” she indignantly said.

“Do I look that old!?”

“Of course not! But he doesn’t mean that either. He’s calling *me* a child, basically” she explained, frowning in disgust. “He always treats me that way, and now the others do the same. Assholes…”

Light Spinner let out a hearty laugh and approached to give her a kiss.

“He’s the one behaving like a toddler, you know?” the sorceress pointed out. “Just disregard him”.

“I try…” she replied. “But he’s always saying things like ‘Does the girl need help to eat?’, ‘Should I get you a bib?’, or ‘Does the baby need her nap?’. Ugh! I hate that! But, yeah… I never respond. I just… ignore it all”.

“Good” she sighed, embracing her. “When will you meet your friends?”

“Next week! At the café, for dinner” Castaspella replied.

“I’m sure it will be great for you”.

“I hope most of them can go. Nights are busier, as you may imagine” she giggled.

“Understandable. But who decided to make it a dinner?”

“Them”.

“Well, if they chose that time it’s because they can go, don’t you think?”

“Yeah… Oh, I wish you could meet them!” Castaspella commented.

“The night is for you and your friends. Eventually, I’ll meet them” she assured her. “Now let’s have lunch”.

The women walked together towards the kitchen, helped each other cook the meal, and finally sat at the small table to eat in silent company. Once they were done, together they washed the dishes and Castaspella got ready to train.

“Well, let’s start” she said, unaware of Light Spinner standing behind her.

However, before she could so much as move her hands, the sorceress stopped her and said "Tomorrow I'll go pick you up at work, and we'll have lunch. How does that sound?"

"Sounds like *someone* will annoy me non-stop afterwards…" she let out, looking away.

"As I said, you should ignore him. And if he tries to call me your 'mother' again, at least I'll be there to prove him wrong" she replied, smirking.

"That sounds like a terrible idea, but… as you wish, I'll be glad" Castaspella sighed. "Now let's start for real".

Just as promised, by the end of her shift the following day, Light Spinner arrived at the café. The women took a seat at a table near the door and spoke in hushed tones.

"Are you sure about this?"

"Are you scared, Es?"

"Of course!"

"No need. Nothing will happen" the sorceress assured her.

"Can I take your order?" a guy suddenly interrupted, his tone tired.

"You can" Light Spinner replied. "Two specialities with a cup of wine each" she requested.

He wrote it down and started walking away while saying "Look at that, allowing underage drinking…"

"That idiot" Castaspella seethed, hands closed in fists over the table.

"Calm down… He's trying to provoke you" she reminded her, gently placing both hands over hers.

The woman slowly calmed down thanks to her, but unfortunately, it didn't last much. Before the food arrived, the waiter returned to deliver the drinks, yet he only brought a single cup of wine, and instead, a glass of water for Castaspella.

"What are you…" she began, indignant, but Light Spinner held her hands tighter and stopped her.

"I believe I asked you for *two* cups of wine, and I never ordered water" she calmly pointed out.

"I'm sorry" he said, carelessly, starting to walk away with his tray half loaded. "Even with the mother present, we won't serve alcohol to minors" he said, smirking without looking back.

“Oh, trust me. A mother wouldn’t do what *I* do with her” Light Spinner shamelessly said, loud enough for him to hear, which also made all the customers around them start whispering, some indignant, some amused.

Crash!

The loud sound made all whispers stop. The sorceress had to make a conscious effort not to laugh, while Castaspella only stared at the waiter frantically picking up the broken pieces from the ground.

When she looked back at Light Spinner, she immediately told her “I just *know* you’re smirking under that veil. You’re terrible…”

“I didn’t lie. And he began…”

“Now he sure won’t leave me in peace” Castaspella lamented.

“Oh, he will” she assured her. "At least for a while".

A different waiter brought them the food, with the second cup of wine, and the women finally enjoyed their lunch.

The week flew and, soon, it was the day of the gathering. Castaspella was anxious all day, excited. And as soon as her shift ended, she went home to get changed before returning to the café.

The night was just beginning when the woman met her former coworkers there. They were all extremely excited to see her, so much so that they made quite a fuss.

“Hey, girl!” one of them called out, with a cheery tone.

“Casta!” another one with pointy ears exclaimed.

“Oh, guys! You’re here!” she greeted them. “Bri, Natch, how are you?” she asked.

“Better now that you’re blessing our eyes with your presence” Bri replied, bowing teasingly.

“Zack will arrive soon, and Cyrus was still getting changed when we left” Natch told her, after greeting her with a kiss on the cheek.

“Let's wait for them at the table” Castaspella proposed. “How’s everything been going lately?”

“Oh, quite good!” Bri replied. “Like I told you last time, we miss you, but you look so happy, we really hope you never come back” they laughed.

“Very funny” she replied. “And how’s…” she began asking, but got interrupted by a pair of individuals with curled back horns arriving. “Zack! Oh my Stars, you brought Archie!” she

noticed.

Castaspella stood up to greet them, and then they all took a seat around the table.

“How did you convince Archie!?” Natch asked, staring at Zack in disbelief.

“I owe them a favour” he replied, smirking. “But it was worth it” he assured.

“Oh, look who comes there…” Bri pointed out, making everyone look at the door.

“Cyrus!” Castaspella exclaimed, standing up again to greet him.

“Casta, Dear. How are you doing?” he asked, clearly happy.

“Better now that you’re all here” she replied, cheerful. “Go ahead, sit down”.

“Well, guys… everyone else is busy tonight, so it will be just us” he announced, finally settling.

They all started chatting amicably and for a while discussed what to order. Once that was decided, they began interrogating Castaspella, who told them in full detail everything she had done since leaving the brothel.

“Hold on” Zack interrupted. “You mean… you’ve had a brother all this time?” he asked.

“Yeah…”

“That’s what surprised you?” Natch reproached him. “Zo was from *up there*! How did we never know!?”

“You’re missing my favourite detail” Bri interrupted. “She basically kidnapped our dear Casta here!”

“Why’s that your favourite detail?” Archie asked.

“Yes, why?” Castaspella seconded, folding her arms but letting out a smirk.

“Just because it’s the reason why we met you, girl!” they immediately replied.

The group laughed in amusement for a moment before the arrival of their food interrupted them, but then quickly returned to the subject.

“So, about that brother of yours. How is he?” Cyrus asked.

“I…haven’t met him that much yet. Only saw him a few times” Castaspella admitted.

“Why!?”

“We started with the wrong foot. And I’m… afraid of his reaction if he ever learns the truth about me…” she sighed. “I’m just afraid overall”.

“Oh, dear…”

The whole group began speaking at the same time, trying to soothe her, and Natch even hugged her tightly, which made her feel immense nostalgia. She had missed them so much…

But then, someone walked through the door, and she couldn’t help staring at him.

“Casta?” Natch asked, before following her line of sight. “Oh. My. Stars” she uttered. “Is that him!?”

As soon as the woman nodded, the entire group turned to look at the sorcerer who had approached the counter to order a coffee.

Immediately, without a second thought, Bri called out “Hey, cutie!”

“Bri!” Castaspella whispered, alarmed.

“Yes, you, cupcake!” they insisted when Micah turned and pointed at himself, questioningly. “Come over, will you, fancy man?” they invited.

Yet he hesitated. Micah saw Castaspella at the table, ashamedly covering her face, and shook his head.

“So-sorry” he uttered.

“Oh, Casta, please tell him to come over!” Bri pleaded.

“Yes, yes!” the rest insisted,

“This is your chance” Zack said. “You have nothing to fear. We’ll be here with you”.

Right.

He was right.

If anything went wrong, they would be there to support her.

Castaspella took a deep breath, turned to look at a very uncomfortable Micah, and nodded once, expression unreadable. It was enough to convince him, so he asked for the coffee to be delivered to the table and walked over.

“Come on, now. Sit here next to me” Bri offered, making space for him at the booth, right in front of Castaspella. “So this delicious specimen is your brother, eh, Casta?” they asked, teasingly.

“Bri…” she reproached them, albeit smiling. “Sorry. First, hello. These are my friends. That’s Bri, next to them is Cyrus, Archie, that’s Zack, and next to me is Natch” she introduced them. “Guys, he’s Micah”.

“Um… hello”.

“Nice to meet you, cutie” Bri immediately said.

“We’re glad to meet you, really” Zack assured him.

“Yeah. If you’re half as good as your sister, we’ll sure like you” Archie laughed.

Micah cleared his throat, nervous having Bri basically resting on his shoulder, and said “Nice to meet you too. Um… where-where did you guys meet?”

He didn’t lose a second, did he?

Castaspella was already uneasy…

“At work” Cyrus replied, right after swallowing a bit of his food.

“Oh. But you don’t work here, do you?” he noticed, just as his coffee arrived.

“Oh, no, honey. We mean her old work” Bri corrected.

And of course, the expected question…

“Then where do you all work?”

“At the brothel” they replied in unison.

Micah choked on his coffee. Bri even had to pat him on the back to help him recover.

Meanwhile, Castaspella was holding her breath, tense from head to toe, jaw clenched.

“That’s… eh… unexpected… So… eh… you are… um… *that*” he stammered.

“What do you mean by ‘that’?” Castaspella inquired, expecting the worst.

“We-well, I don’t know what to call it… Eh… I don’t mean to offend” he replied.

Oh…

The woman immediately exhaled. She could breathe easily.

It wasn’t like that nightmare months ago. He was actually being respectful.

“As long as you don’t call us ‘whores’ we’re chill” Natch assured him.

“S-so… um… ‘prostitutes’ is alright?” he asked, increasingly nervous.

“Oh, I always liked the term ‘courtesan’ more. It’s so sophisticated” Bri pointed out.

“Um, so, that” he nodded, blushing.

“Oh, he’s so cute! Look at him all red” they giggled.

Zack smirked at Casta, and she smiled back, grateful.

“I really missed this” he said, still looking at her. “You should visit us for Drinking Night!” he suggested.

“I-I don’t know. I don’t think Boss would be okay with that” she doubted.

“To hell with Boss! You’re still one of us!” Archie countered, seconded by the rest.

Still one of them… It inevitably made the sorcerer shiver.

“I… You all seem to get along really well. You really like her” Micah finally said, changing the subject.

“Of course! Our Casta here has always been our rough diamond” Natch said, giving her a kiss on the cheek again. “She’s so skilled”.

“I heard as much” he nodded. “Well, I, eh, in magic, at least. That’s what I know” he clarified, even more nervous.

“Oh, absolutely” Archie immediately agreed. “Her defence spells…”

“Right!” Natch exclaimed. “Remember when those two guys were fighting for me!? Even after paying… Stars! They almost tore me in two!” she retold. “Casta somehow pushed them back and neither dared touch me again” she concluded.

“Oh, oh! Remember the guy with the knife?” Cyrus asked. “Even after I told him I was *not* into that, he still insisted, and Casta kept the knife from cutting me! His face was so funny!” he laughed. “That one was great!”

“What about the idiot who almost choked me?” Archie recalled. “I still don’t know what Casta did, but hell! Now, *that* was impressive” they sentenced.

“You all…”

“Owe her?” Bri interrupted Micah. “Yes, pretty much, cupcake” they assured. “Let’s not forget that nutjob of a woman that threw bottles at us” they recalled.

“Casta covered us all with a shield until all the bottles of the bar were gone” Natch completed.

“That’s… yeah, impressive, Sis” he let out.

Sis…

That term was… unexpected.

Castaspella lowered her head, pensive for a moment, before taking a deep breath and looking up again.

“Thank you” she finally said. “I always took care of them to the best of my abilities”.

“Yeah! We’re her family!” Natch said, embracing her with one arm. “No offence” she then added.

“None taken” Micah replied.

“Now tell us about you, cupcake” Bri began, teasing his beard. “We want to know…”

“I-I…” he began, stammering, and cleared his throat. “Well, I have a family” he finally managed to say, picking a random subject.

“Oh, is that so?” Bri asked, even more interested now.

“Yes. But I’ve been away from them the past few years” he explained.

“Where do they live?” Zack asked.

“Have you heard of Bright Moon?” Micah questioned them.

They all gasped.

“But that’s so far away!” Cyrus pointed out.

“Exactly. I’m missing my little girl’s childhood” he admitted.

“Aww, you have a baby daughter! That’s adorable!” Bri commented. “Now, now. Who’s the other parent?” they asked, teasing his beard again.

“Um… Her name is Angella…”

“Wait! As in *Queen* Angella!?” Zack interrupted, shocked.

“Oh, Stars!” Bri exclaimed. “A *king*! No wonder you’re such a cutie” they laughed. “What a shame you’re taken…”

“Why are you living in Mystacor then?” Castaspella asked, finally speaking up again.

“There’s something dangerous brewing on the island…” he replied.

“Tell us” Zack requested.

“I don’t think you’d be interested. Normally, people from the surface don’t care about the issues of the island” he argued.

“Well, if it’s dangerous… it might affect us” Natch reflected. “It’s right over us”.

“Yeah. You just go ahead and tell us” Archie insisted.

“Well, Light Spinner… My mentor…” he began, clarifying for the rest who he meant. “She discovered this… dangerous, ancient magic that’s growing within the kingdom. She told the

council there was a way of sealing the magic, controlling it to take its power, but they rejected the project. So instead, she proposed preparing some defences to protect the kingdom from that chaotic magic. The day it finally breaks loose, we'll need everyone to defend us from it. That plan was accepted, and we have been keeping an eye on that magic while training our defence spells to be perfect and effective" he elaborated. "I wish I could just go home, but they need me here, and the trip is too long to risk it" he added.

"Oh, you poor thing…" Bri said, caressing his cheek and letting out a giggle as he turned red again.

"So that's why she wanted to train me?" Castaspella asked him.

"Didn't she tell you about the threat we face?"

"She had me read about Mystacor's history and some ancient magic, but that was it. I guess I never asked either" she admitted.

"You're exceedingly good at defence magic. The-they all just confirmed it! And she told me she hopes you will be ready in time to help us with that thing. Now I understand why" he assured her.

"But then… I have a question" Castaspella continued. "Can't, perhaps, your wife help you?" she asked. "She's an angelic being, right?"

"Ho-how's that related?"

"According to what I read, that magic was originally sealed by angelic beings" she explained.

"Oh, smart Casta" Bri teased. "I like that".

"I don't know much about that magic. What else do you know?" Micah asked.

"I-I don't think we should be discussing this now…"

"Hey, no! I want to know!" Natch complained.

"Yeah, spill the tea!" Archie pleaded.

"Fine, fine" she accepted, raising her hands as if giving up. "What I know is that it's unpredictable magic, with a conscience of its own. In fact, it's a magical leech. Originally, it was like the embodiment of all kinds of dangerous magical energies that some angelic beings sealed away to keep the world safe from it" she explained. "So, it's dangerous, powerful, and has a consciousness, but it can't do much on its own. It requires a caster to unleash its full potential" she then added. "So, from what you tell me, what I suppose, is that it's seeking more power, and even someone to corrupt who would help it break free from the remaining seal" Castaspella reflected.

For a moment, an uncomfortable quietness settled, and they even stopped eating. But, of course, Bri didn't shy away from breaking the silence.

“That’s so scary… I’m impressed, but I think I’ll have nightmares” they admitted.

“How dangerous would it be if it broke free?” Natch asked, trying to hide her fear.

“If it managed to find a caster, and they survived, it would give them immense powers at a cost just as high. It’s a give-and-take. But, in any case, it all would depend on the caster. If they decide to attack… we would be at great risk, indeed. But perhaps they don’t, in which case it would pose no threat” Castaspella replied.

“So there’s a chance nothing happens?” Cyrus asked.

“I don’t know how the situation in Mystacor is. It’s all theoretical. It may still hurt a lot of people up there if it just tries to… *force* someone into being its caster” she reflected.

“I see…” Micah sighed. “That’s all very useful. Thank you” he nodded.

Again, there was silence for a moment. And once more, Bri spoke up first.

“Well! Let’s change subjects now, because this is getting grim as hell” they requested, taking a bite of their food. “Why don’t we share some stories about our dear Casta?” they proposed, much to her mortification.

“Oh, no, no. Please” she pleaded, but it was too late.

For the rest of the dinner, her friends told story after story, mostly embarrassing Castaspella, but also making Micah laugh a lot. It made her feel more at ease, seeing him interact with her friends so happily and, finally, all her fears vanished.

Once the food was gone, they arranged the payment of the bill and got ready to leave.

“So! When do we gather next time!?” Natch asked.

“Monday next week?” Archie suggested.

“It’s the monthly medical check-up day. I haven’t forgotten” Castaspella reminded them.

“Oh, that’s right. *I* forgot” they laughed.

“Just come to the next Drinking Night, Casta” Zack invited her.

“And you better bring that sorceress of yours” Bri added, resting their head on their hand over the table. “Oh, and this delight of a man too”.

Micah’s face turned red again, and he had to clear his throat to hide his nervousness, which made everyone laugh again as they finally left the table and headed out.

Once outside the café, the group said their goodbyes to Castaspella. And, as they tried to make Bri let go of Micah, Zack went to speak with her.

“See? It wasn’t that bad” he told her, smiling gently.

“I wouldn’t have been able to do it without you all” she admitted. “Thank you for the support”.

“Any time, Casta” he assured her. “Now let’s remind Bri that’s a married man” he laughed.

“When has that stopped Bri from simping?” Castaspella laughed too.

As they pulled them away from Micah, light-heartedly telling them off, Zack remained next to the sorcerer for a moment, only to exhort them “Walk her home, alright?”

He then joined his friends, and they all walked away, back to the brothel, singing together and laughing. Castaspella waved at them with a bright smile, and sighed deeply. When she turned around, Micah was shyly standing there, gathering the strength to follow Zack’s advice.

“Erm… Do you- Ca-can I walk you home, maybe?” he hesitantly asked.

“I… Yeah, sure” she finally agreed, looking at him with half a smile and a softer look.

“I’m so sorry for… everything that happened last time at your door” he began as they walked side by side down the street. “And I’m glad to see you have such good friends” he continued. “I won’t lie to you, I’m shocked they are… What was the term? Courtesans?”

“Does that bother you?” Castaspella asked, looking at the front, her tone notoriously severe.

“I- No- Well. Ah…” he stammered, and sighed. “I suppose my real problem is that *you* used to work with them. I can’t believe it” he admitted.

“It’s an honest job, Micah. I’ve always been proud of it” she told him.

“I understand. It’s… alright” he finally said. “I’m just glad you’re alright” he insisted.

“Well…” Castaspella let out as they arrived at her flat. “It was… nice chatting with you” she said, extending her hand for him to shake. “Good night” she farewelled.

After hesitating a moment, he shook her hand and replied “Likewise. Good night”.

Chapter End Notes

I have the feeling Bri will be your favourite. I mean, their personality is quite particular, but something tells me that's exactly why they will be the most popular of Casta's friends. Oh, just you wait for the Drinking Night scenes hehe

Alright, that was all for today!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

I also like this chapter very much, but the previous one is still my fav I have to say...

But I hope you like it, there's more about Casta's backstory, some insight into Mystacor (there will be more in the future), and some into Micah's mental state lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Will you go with me? Please, please!” Castaspella begged. “Please!” she insisted, extending the word.

“Maybe if you gave me two seconds to reply…” Light Spinner managed to utter before the woman could say another word.

“So-sorry” she apologized with an ashamed smile.

The sorceress gently grabbed her chin and tilted her face up to look her in the eyes as she accepted “Gladly”.

“Thank you!” Castaspella exclaimed, grinning brightly.

She hugged Light Spinner tightly and celebrated with small jumps.

“You’re happy with so little…” the sorceress let out, giving her a fond look.

“Oh, and… Um… Well. My friends asked me to invite Micah too, but I have no way of contacting him, so if you could do me the favour…” she then requested, shyly looking away.

“Of course, Es. I will” she promised.

About two weeks later, Drinking Night finally arrived. Before leaving, the women got ready at the flat; Castaspella put on the same blue short dress she was using when the sorceress first saw her, while Light Spinner put on her formal robes.

“Only *you* would go to a bar in such clothing” the woman laughed.

“It’s the best outfit I have” the sorceress complained.

“I should make you a dress or something”.

“No, no. No tailoring for you, miss” Light Spinner quickly denied. “You’re falling behind in your studies”.

“Excuse you!? I’m keeping a steady pace! I think I’m going quite well” Castaspella confidently countered.

“That’s for me to judge, and I say you’re becoming lazy” she insisted.

“How mean!”

“I’m just stating facts”.

“No! You’re being a bitch about it!” the woman complained.

“Who says it can’t be both?” the sorceress argued, smirking.

“Forget it” she grunted. “We should get going”.

“Alright” Light Spinner agreed, putting on her veil. “If you’re ready…”

The women finally left the place and unhurriedly walked down the street towards the brothel. The night was chilly, enough to give Castaspella goosebumps, but she knew it would be far warmer once inside, so she didn’t give it much importance.

Instead, she decided to ask “So, did you tell Micah where to go and the time?”

“I did. He said he would meet us there” Light Spinner replied, without looking back at her. “Something tells me we’ll find him awkwardly standing outside” she commented.

Castaspella chortled and pointed out “You know him well”.

“Quite. He’s been my pupil since he was around fourteen years or so” she replied.

“That’s a lot of time” the woman sighed. “And… You said you didn’t know about me… Hadn’t you ever seen me, either?”

“No. You were taken when you were, perhaps, eight. He said he was twelve when it happened so, if my calculations are right, you must have been either seven or eight” she replied, pensive. “Yes, I remember I was twenty-three when that woman left the island, then twenty-five when I started mentoring him, and I’m quite sure he was at least fourteen by then” she reflected.

“Oh… wow. Then it’s strange that I don’t remember him at all…” Castaspella pointed out.

“Not so strange for Mystacor” the sorceress denied. “Kids are kept in nurseries for toddlers until they are five, and then in school-nurseries until they are twelve. Which means you didn’t see your brother more than two years, the first when you were literally months old, and the second when you entered school-nursery, right before he left it” Light Spinner elaborated. “You would have met him again once you were old enough to start your magical training like him, but you were taken years before that”.

“That’s… Wow. What a complicated system. And I think it sucks for siblings with such an age gap” she commented. Then, as she thought about it better, it occurred to her “I can’t believe I never asked this, but… Why did Zo take *me* from all kids?”

“Ah… I thought you would never ask” Light Spinner admitted with a snicker. “The short answer is that she was your assigned mentor”.

“And the long answer?”

“But we’re about to arrive…”

“I don’t care” Castaspella replied, stopping in her tracks and folding her arms as she looked back at her. “Tell me, and then we’ll walk the rest of the way there”.

“I thought you were excited to arrive” Light Spinner pointed out.

“But I want to know, so I’m willing to wait a bit more” she argued.

“Why not later?”

“I will forget! First, I’ll probably return too drunk, and tomorrow, I’ll be too hung-over. So I’m sure I’ll simply forget about it” she argued. “Please, tell me now”.

“Very well” the sorceress sighed. “The long answer is that the two years you were in school-nursery, you had a dozen tutors before her. You would barely last a month with each, sometimes less, until she took you under her care. Knowing that must have made her so adamant to be the mother you didn’t have, and I suppose she couldn’t bear abandoning you as they did” she explained. “Or so I could guess from my investigations. Unfortunately, it had been almost five years since then, and very few recalled either of you” she clarified.

So, the woman took her because she loved her like a mother?

Everyone abandoned her before, and she didn’t want to do the same!?

And her bright idea was to take her down to a world of…

No.

That… It was not worth thinking about.

“Alright, that’s enough” Castaspella sighed. “Thank you for telling me… Let’s go” she said.

“Cheer up, Es. The underlying message is that she loved you as much as a mother would. She isn’t the villain of your story” Light Spinner told her, holding her hand as they walked around the corner.

The woman only gave her a sad smile as a reply before looking back to the front and realising Micah was, just as the sorceress said, expecting them at the door of the brothel.

“You were *so* right” she muttered.

“Of course” she proudly replied. “Good evening, Micah” she greeted him when they reached the entrance. “Shall we?”

“Go-good evening” he stammered, giving Castaspella a nervous look. “Yes… Right… Let’s…”

The three of them went in, and the atmosphere completely changed; there was music, the lights were low, and the temperature was notoriously warmer than outside.

Just as the woman remembered it. Even after a whole year, nothing seemed to have changed.

Behind the counter, Bri was having fun mixing a couple of drinks, while most of her friends sat on the stools or directly on top of the bar. They received Castaspella with a loud outcry, which startled Micah, as he absolutely wasn’t expecting them to practically go crazy over her arrival.

Three empty stools waited for them, and they promptly took a seat as Bri invited “Come on now, don’t be shy and join the party! What do I serve you?”

“You know what I like” Castaspella replied.

“Of course, girl. Coming right up!” they exclaimed.

“I’ll have some wine, if you don’t mind” Light Spinner requested.

“Oh, fancy!” Bri let out. “And you, cupcake?”

“I-I don’t know…”

“Let me surprise you then” they offered.

“A-alright. Of course” he accepted, unable to hide his nervousness.

Just as promised, Castaspella’s drink was served almost immediately, and the woman grabbed it before straightening her back and crossing her legs to be more comfortable. However, that made Micah notice how much skin she was showing, and it made him extremely uncomfortable. So much so, that Bri noticed when they served him the mysterious cocktail.

Oh, no. That wouldn’t do…

“Her dress is quite eye-catching, right?” they asked Micah, calling his attention.

“Um, eye-catching. Right…”

“I made it myself” Castaspella commented, obviously proud.

“Really?” he asked, impressed.

“She also made mine! Like it?” Bri told him, showing off a golden version of the woman’s dress.

“I- Wow. That’s actually… impressive” he had to admit.

“We told you she’s really skilled” Bri reminded him with a nudge.

After a few drinks, Castaspella was laughing with her friends while, always by her side, Light Spinner silently listened and drank her wine. Natch and Archie were the most talkative ones, but Cyrus would always find a way of reclaiming attention. And then… a particular song started playing, making everyone yell in excitement. Apparently, it was a favourite of both, customers and workers, and Natch pulled Castaspella for a dance, something they used to do a lot, it seemed.

Bri could have sworn they saw a hint of jealousy in Light Spinner’s eyes, and couldn’t help leaning over the counter to ask “Is our prominent sorceress envious by any chance?”

“Nonsense” she denied, shaking her head slightly and with half a smile under the veil. “But I’m quite amused. Tell me the truth: your friend, Natch… she likes Castaspella, doesn’t she?”

“As a friend or as something more?” they asked, playing dumb. However, the sorceress only gave them a stern look and they admitted “Fine, yes. They had a brief relationship long ago, but that was it. We do mock Natch saying she’s still head over heels for Casta, but I can’t say for sure”.

“It makes sense then” she nodded.

“How did you notice?”

“I’m not blind” Light Spinner replied, rolling her eyes. “The kisses, inviting her to dance so close… Just look at Natch. Her eyes are practically shining” she noted.

“Very observant” they admitted. “I’m impressed”.

“But, don’t worry. I have no issues with her. I’m confident in my relationship with Castaspella” she assured them.

“That’s so sweet!” they exclaimed. Right after, they pointed out “Oh, look who’s coming your way…”

“No more dancing for you?” the sorceress asked.

“Oh, no. I’m dancing with *you* now” Castaspella corrected her. “Come on” she insisted, grabbing her hands.

“Stars…” the sorceress sighed, before complying.

Now, it was time for them to dance close, which obviously made Micah uncomfortable again. He asked for another drink and told himself to ignore it all. The looks, the “concealed” touches, the proximity… It was driving him crazy.

Before they could enjoy the night much more, the boss of the brothel showed up. Castaspella was sitting on her stool, sipping her drink carelessly, when she noticed her shocked friends all

around, and only then did she see the man. Dressed in a black suit and flanked by a pair of guards, he approached the bar, all smiles.

“Well, well! Look who we have here!” he exclaimed, his sight fixed on Castaspella. “Pleased to finally meet you”.

“Oh my Stars, Boss” she realised, hesitant. “Eh, nice to meet you too” she managed to answer.

“It’s a shame I didn’t make your acquaintance when you still worked for me. I had to hire almost twice as much security as before after your partner generously paid off your debt” he added, nodding in acknowledgement at Light Spinner, who raised her cup at him in reply.

Although, at first, Micah didn’t even want to see him knowing who he was, and despite shivering at the word ‘partner’, he had to admit he was surprised again. Too surprised.

Castaspella, without formal training, made up for half their security!?

“Mhm, he’s right” Bri let out, in a low tone, leaning closer to the woman. “We had a few complicated weeks last year”.

Micah was close enough to hear, and asked “You depended on her so much!?”

Being a bit drunk already, his voice sounded louder than intended, and the boss heard the question too, yet he only laughed in amusement.

“Oh, please trust me. Had I known that was the case, I would have hired more security earlier. I take care of everyone here, and would have never imposed such responsibility on her” he replied.

“I imagine you wouldn’t…” Light Spinner uttered, with an ambiguous tone.

“Not without some extra payment at least” he clarified.

“So that’s why you returned part of the payment?”

“Perhaps…” he replied, looking away and pretending innocence.

“Castaspella!” a voice suddenly called, one that she could easily recognize.

Not *him*…

Everyone looked back at the guy who had just entered the brothel; both Light Spinner and Micah put down their glasses, and the woman stood up from her stool.

“No, no” Natch muttered, standing by her side and grabbing her wrist. “He’s been demented this last year” she told her, worried.

“You are back!” he exclaimed, stumbling forward, obviously drunk.

“Sorry to break it to you, but she’s not” Bri commented from behind the counter.

“Bullshit!” he immediately spat. “You all were… were hiding her from me” he angrily accused.

“Who’s he?” Micah asked.

“A former habitué of hers” one of Castaspella’s friends explained, making the sorcerer gulp uneasy.

“She is out of commission” the boss assured him.

“Nah, nah! You can’t be! I *pay* for you!” the guy insisted, always looking at her.

“I may be tipsy, but don’t think for a second I’ll let you touch me” Castaspella threatened, already positioning her hands to draw a spell.

“Oh, it’s showtime” Bri said, mildly excited.

The boss could recognize that stance from his mother, and immediately interrupted her with a gesture.

“I have told you before… This is your last chance. Another scandal and you will be banned” he warned him.

“I have the right! I am the client! I am loyal!” he argued, dragging the words. “Now! To the back!” he ordered, trying to head for the rooms.

“I warned you” the boss let out, before gesturing at his guards. The men took the obnoxious guy by the arms and dragged him out of the brothel. He let out a sigh, exasperated. “I apologize to you all” he then told everyone. “I know he’s not the only violent client, so please don’t hesitate to call for the guards if you’re the slightest bit uncomfortable” he reminded them.

“Thank you, Boss” Castaspella’s friends said, almost at the same time.

“Is it the alcohol or is Boss far more, eh, involved than before?” she asked, in general, once he walked away.

“Actually, your leave foiled everything in here when it comes to life quality” one of her friends began, sitting over the bar next to Micah, who was *very* focused on his glass now. “Boss had no idea how many things you did for us. There were suddenly a lot of issues with the clients, a lot of complaints from us, and a ton of demands when it comes to clothing!”

“Oh, right… I-I forgot” Castaspella realised.

“But he found ways to make up for it all. Now, there’s a fund for new clothes and any mendings we might need. There’s also new security for all of us… We’re doing pretty well, trust me!” Natch assured her, smirking.

“That’s good to know…” she let out, yawning. “Oh, my… I have to work tomorrow” she remembered.

“And you have had enough drinks” Light Spinner pointed out, holding her from behind. “So I believe it’s time for us to retire. Don’t you think?”

“Yeah, yeah… Before I can’t even walk back home” she accepted.

“I can always carry you back” the sorceress pointed out, making some of Castaspella’s friends snicker, while Micah groaned. “Come on, let’s go” she insisted, gently guiding her by the shoulders.

“Goodbye, everyone!” she farewelled, waving in their general direction.

Their replies drowned each other, but she could easily understand each of their voices. The best ending for the night.

Light Spinner steered her down the street all the way back to the flat, while hearing her rant about the guy from the brothel.

“How could you stand him for two whole years?” she finally asked, shocked.

“It wasn’t bad at first. It got terrible the second year, and would have been even worse had you not found me” Castaspella replied, her tone dissonant. “Please tell me you’re not mad” she then added, making it more evident just how drunk she was.

“Why would I be?”

“Why not!? Like… Like the, uh, the guy, that idiot… and the, eh, the others you haven’t even seen… Or, or even… you were looking at Natch like, like *murder*” she replied, shaking her head. “I don’t feel so well” she suddenly admitted.

“I wonder why” the sorceress sighed. “Es, perhaps you shouldn’t have drank so much” she commented, catching the woman right as she tripped. “Careful”.

“Sorry” Castaspella apologized. “Ma-maybe it’s not a bad idea to carry me” she had to admit.

“I take it you *want* me to carry you?”

“Maybe”.

“Alright” Light Spinner laughed, before hooking an arm around her torso and the other under her legs. “There we go” she said, as she lifted her. “Comfortable?”

“Very” the woman nodded, resting her head on the sorceress’ chest. “You’re warm”.

“Am I?” she chuckled.

“Mhmm…”

“It’s alright if you fall asleep, Es. We’re almost there” she assured her.

“But I don’t want to fall asleep” she argued, pouting.

“And what exactly is so important that you wish to remain awake?”

“You”.

“Es…” Light Spinner sighed, smiling. “I see… But I think you need sleep more than sex, right now”.

“Bea! Please!”

“I am serious”.

“So am I”.

“It’s hard to take you seriously when you’re so drunk, you know?”

“Mean!”

“Regardless, you will be too sleepy for that” the sorceress argued.

“No” Castaspella replied, stretching the word. “Alcohol doesn’t make *me* sleepy. It makes me hyperactive!” she told her, confident.

“We’ll see…” Light Spinner defied her, right as they arrived at the flat. Once they were inside, she sent the woman to the bedroom, expecting her to fall asleep immediately, and said “I’ll be there soon”.

The sorceress went to the kitchen for a glass of cold water, took a moment to breathe calmly while looking through the window, and finally headed for the room.

However, much to her surprise, Castaspella was very well awake, and waiting for her naked on the bed.

“Should I help you with that?”

“I’ll undress myself, thank you”.

“Bummer” the woman complained.

“Sometimes I forget just how persistent you can be…”

“But you like that from me, don’t you?”

“I do” Light Spinner admitted.

“Then come here at last” she urged her.

“Alright, alright”.

The sorceress sat down on the bed next to Castaspella and leant forward to kiss her. Soon, they were touching each other, gradually reaching for the most sensitive zones, and it wasn't long before they began panting.

Only the exhaustion that came afterwards managed to knock out Castaspella, who, just as she had said, was restless. It was perhaps four in the morning when they both fell soundly asleep, tired but satisfied.

Meanwhile, back in the bar of the brothel, the sorcerer was ordering yet another drink, while hearing, yet not listening, to Castaspella's former coworkers talk around him. He paid them no mind as they discussed clients, pay rates, anecdotes, and preferences.

Nope, he didn't want to know.

Because they might not be Castaspella, but they could have been… If it happened to them, it could have happened to her. This had been her world.

And he couldn't deal with it.

It was, however, impossible to ignore Bri, as they were the one controlling the drinks.

"Oh, no, Sir" they sentenced, snatching the glass from his hands. "It's enough for you".

"I say when… it's enough" he replied, dragging the words and talking slower than usual.

"Look, honey. It's obvious you're uncomfortable here. Why haven't you left?" Bri asked, genuinely confused and starting to get concerned.

"Because I want another drink" he answered, his tone dissonant.

"I really don't think that's a good idea" they insisted.

"I-I never asked for your opinion".

"Fine!" they exclaimed, offended. "Just one more drink, but with one condition, cupcake" they said. "You have to tell me why you're drowning in alcohol".

"You won't like it" he warned them.

"I'll be the judge of that".

"I… *hate* almost everything about my sister's life".

"That's a bold statement".

"I hate that… that she worked here. And that she's now… now… with *my mentor*!"

"Oh, we all realised, honey" Bri assured him. "But why?"

“Do-don’t misunderstand” Micah began. “You’re her friends, and you’re obviously good people. You make her happy”.

“But?”

“You also represent… *all of this*” he said, gesturing all around. “And I hate that she… lived here. *Worked* here” he went on. “And… and I can’t… bear the thought of… her and my mentor being *intimate*!”

“Oh, cutie… Poor you” they said, trying not to laugh. “No one likes the thought of their family being intimate with anyone, you know?”

“And you say it… As if… as if you weren’t used to it…”

“No, no, no. Don’t confuse things, sweetheart” Bri interrupted him. “Here we have a different concept of intimacy, and we consider each other family, yes. But we’re not blood-related like you and your sis, so I get it. For you, it’s a nightmare”.

“And everything here reminds me what… what she obviously did when she… worked here” he added.

“Ah… right” Bri sighed. “Well, I won’t lie to you. She probably did everything you think and more, but it doesn’t mean anything, alright?”

“How!?”

“Because sex, without feelings, means nothing” they replied.

“Right…”

“Listen, sugar. Just *don’t* think about any of it. When the thoughts appear, just force yourself to think about something else” Bri suggested. “You will *always* be reminded of this, but if you’re gonna break down like this every time, you’ll die of alcohol poisoning!” they insisted.

“I can’t do this” he lamented, resting his forehead on the counter.

“Come on, cupcake. You can”.

“No…”

“If you can’t deal with this, I fear the day your *daughter* has a partner” Bri let out, rolling their eyes.

“Not that!” he screamed, raising his head again.

“Accept it. It will happen. And you should focus on her *happiness*! The same goes for now! Don’t you see Casta is happy!? That’s the only thing you should care about!”

“I try!”

“Keep trying. Isn’t she worth the effort?” Bri insisted.

“She… She is” Micah sighed, with a defeated expression.

“Alright, honey. That’s enough therapy for you. It’s time you return to your fancy island” they said, retrieving the glass from his hands. “Can you go back on your own?”

“Sure…” he was replying, while getting off the stool, but tripped and fell face-first on the floor. “Okay, no. I can’t” he admitted.

“Alright. I’ll walk you there” Bri decided. “It’s an excellent excuse to go take a look at that place” they realised.

“It’s a long way up there…”

“I’m sure it is, but fortunately, I’m free tonight. So let me fetch my coat, and we’ll go”.

Unhurriedly, Bri went for their brown overcoat, then walked round the counter to help the sorcerer up, as he had resigned to sit down there, and they both left the brothel, walking slowly.

Micah’s balance was terrible, so Bri had to keep an arm around him at all times.

He began talking incoherently, but Bri could deduce he was talking about his family. He would speak of wings and sparkles, pink hair, purple eyes… They weren’t sure whether Micah described his wife or his daughter, probably both, but it gave them a clearer image of them, which they found quite endearing.

And then, as they finally arrived at the island, being over the clouds it was easier to see the stars, and Bri was left speechless.

“The… sky” they sighed, fascinated. “It’s beautiful!”

“You hadn’t seen stars before?” he asked, seemingly back to his senses.

“Nope, nor moons” they admitted, admiring the three moons, close to aligning.

“Those are the… eh… the Moons of Enchantment. Yes, that’s the name”.

“They are stunning”.

“Yeah…”

“Oh, but, we’re here now, so, where should I take you?” Bri decided to ask, suddenly remembering where they were.

“There should be some… some acolyte guarding the entrance” Micah explained. “Then I can go to my room”.

“Alright, let's go…”

With some effort, the both of them reached the entrance to the first building and, just as expected, an acolyte stood guard. He gave them a weird look as they approached, but didn't say a word until they showed interest in going inside.

"King Micah!?" he realised. "But where…"

"He is *very* drunk, in case you haven't noticed, so you need to get him to his room as soon as possible" Bri warned him.

"Where do you come from?"

"The bar! Duh!"

"I-I see. Right…" he reluctantly accepted, albeit suspiciously. "I can't leave my post, so you'll have to take him to his room yourself".

"No, no, I can do…" 'It', he was supposed to say, but fell to the ground again. "Fine, I can't".

"Are you serious!?" Bri exclaimed, addressing the acolyte. "He needs help!"

"In our experience, all he needs is some sleep. I'll give you half an hour to take him to his room. It's on the second floor to your right" he finally said, fed up.

"Incredible…" Bri muttered, as they began the arduous trip to the sorcerer's room.

Chapter End Notes

Btw: I wrote "hung-over" but one grammar corrector told me to use "hung over" and another to use "hungover" and then in some dictionaries it appears as "hung-over" as I wrote... Just if you want, would you tell me how you write it? Because I couldn't find consensus about it, and it's driving me crazy...

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> In this chapter I offer some backstory for you all, answers to questions you may or may not have, and a funny little incident which you may find as funny as I intend…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Waking up was hellish for Castaspella. A killer headache assailed her, and she could barely eat her breakfast, as her stomach was just as upset as her head. A horrible morning, indeed. She had had similar mornings before, so she knew that, by evening, she would be fresh and renewed. This time, however, it was a problem because *mornings are her busier time of the day now*, and her shift was about to begin…

"Drink this" Light Spinner ordered, putting down a glass in front of her. "It will perk you up".

"What even is this?" she asked, taking a look at the viscous substance filling the glass. "And why is it blue?"

"It's what you need" the sorceress answered, calmly sipping her tea. "It will help you enough. In just a few hours, not even the headache will remain" she assured her.

"Why won't you tell me what it is?" Castaspella insisted, annoyed.

"Because you have no need to know…"

"Mean…"

"Stop being a baby and drink it up".

While the texture was the world's most hideous experience ever, the taste wasn't that bad. The woman managed to swallow it all and took a deep breath, preparing herself to face the rest of the day. It would certainly feel longer than usual…

But she had to go.

Castaspella finally left her flat and dragged herself across the street towards her workplace. They were just opening, so she was in time to help raise the iron curtain, yet the reflection of the sun on the window worsened her headache and she almost dropped everything.

Similar issues continued to happen, as the loudness of the clients would easily trigger the pain again, and throughout the day, Castaspella made the sound decision of avoiding conversation with her coworkers. She was in no condition to bear them mocking her as usual.

The cook, on the other hand, the nice cook, noticed she was having a *really* bad time and was careful to speak quietly when he went to see her during her break with a plate of chopped fruit.

“Here. Some watery and vitamin fruits will help with that headache” he softly said. “Especially the watery ones if this is a hangover; you’re dehydrated”.

“Thanks…”

“You’re welcome” he replied, smiling gently before leaving her alone once more.

Oh, and how sweet the fruit was! Castaspella enjoyed a refreshing meal along with some peace and quiet for the rest of her break, and only then returned to work.

But now, she was on cleaning duty in the kitchen, and it was becoming increasingly difficult for her to ignore her coworkers. Especially the idiot who kept taunting her.

“Wakey, wakey!” he said, clapping. “Some of us have to *move* around here. You can’t take forever to sweep the floor” he complained, before leaving with a full tray. Shortly after, he was back again, rolling his eyes at her, exaggerating his annoyance. A while later, he taunted her once more “Seriously, are you even here with us or is the baby asleep!?”

“Leave the woman be” the cook yelled at the waiter. “Don’t you see she already feels bad enough?”

“Don’t tell me you’re hung-over!” he realised.

“Shut up” Castaspella finally said, before they left with another food order.

She was fuming. She really hoped he would stop it, just that day. But, of course, as soon as he was back, he picked up where he left off.

“I’m in shock!” he laughed. “First the wine the other day… now you got drunk, when? Last night?” he enumerated.

“Shut up…”

“Should I report that woman for allowing underage drinking?” he joked.

“Stop talking about her!” Castaspella ordered, throwing the broom to the floor.

“Or what? Will you go running back to your mummy…?” he was saying, before being pushed back against the wall with great strength.

In front of him, the woman had taken a fighting stance, and a bright light-blue spell pulsed between them.

“Shut up! Stop talking about my partner that way!” she yelled. “You’re a piece of shit! An imbecile! And you better shut up before that mouth of yours gets you killed!”

Everyone went silent, even outside the kitchen, and it wasn't long before their boss showed up.

"What on Etheria is going on here!?" the manager asked, panicked, having arrived just a second later.

"Would you care to explain why one of my employees is lying against the wall, looking like shit?" the boss calmly inquired with a deep voice, folding his arms.

"Was it you!?" the manager insisted, pointing at Castaspella, who barely had the energy to blink. "Well!?"

"Yeah, it was me…" she admitted, letting out a sigh and making a huge effort to keep herself from falling to the ground. "If- Yeah, no. He wouldn't shut up… I didn't mean to" she added, first wanting to justify herself, then preferring to apologize.

"What is *wrong* with you!?" the manager yelled at her, making the woman flinch with a sudden spike of pain. Obviously on the brink of a nervous collapse, they groaned and went to yank the waiter to his feet, albeit more interested in verifying nothing was broken. "Alright, alright. No smashed appliances. That's good" they let out, speaking calmly for once.

"Sh-she's crazy!" the guy finally said, looking around uneasily. "She-she used *magic* to toss me away!" he accused her, making Castaspella roll her eyes.

"That's bullshit, and you know it!" the cook loudly said, in a mocking tone.

"Dude! Did you see that!?" the waiter argued.

"You wanna know what I saw?" he replied, leaving everything to approach them. "I saw *you*, every day since she was hired, mocking the hell out of her. Calling her a 'baby', a 'toddler', a 'kid', and calling her *partner* her 'mom'. So, yeah, I saw that. She gave you a well-deserved kick in the ass, idiot!"

"Enough" the boss sentenced, gesturing at the cook to step back. "Is that true?" he asked Castaspella. When she nodded, he sighed "I see…"

"I apologize" she began. "I shouldn't have used magic this way, or in any other. And… I understand if you want to fire me" she said. "This was only my fault".

"You think!?" the manager exclaimed. "I expected you to know better than this!"

"I apologize".

"Good" the boss let out, eyes closed. "This time, you only get a warning. But next time, gather your things and leave before I discover you" he informed her.

Right after, he pulled the manager with him as he left, and everything went silent again. Everyone returned to their duties, and no one spoke another word for the remaining of the shift.

A few hours later, when her turn was done, she changed from the café's uniform to her casual clothing, gathered her things, and headed for the door before anyone could speak to her.

However, Castaspella was stopped by her boss at the entrance on her way out.

"Oh, Boss, eh, I'm sorry" she stammered.

"Easy, you can calm down" he said, speaking more gently than earlier. "Now that you're off work, I can tell you this: Ignore the kid. He's just twenty. That may be why he messes with you so much" he explained, making Castaspella cover her mouth with both hands to keep herself from screaming. "Oh, right. And excuse my spouse's behaviour today" he added.

"Oh, of course. I understand. They seemed quite nervous with everything that happened".

"I appreciate the comprehension. Now, you're free to go. See you on Monday, and enjoy your free day" he farewelled, returning inside.

That afternoon, while having some tea, Castaspella told Light Spinner everything that happened in full detail, inevitably amused when she mentioned pushing back the waiter.

"You should have seen his face!" she exclaimed. "Oh, oh! And when the cook went to confront him with all the bullshit he's been doing!? Hah!"

"I imagine it must have been quite the sight" the sorceress let out, smirking.

"You have no idea!" she laughed.

"Yes, yes… but you must be careful. Wouldn't like to be fired, would you?" Light Spinner warned her.

"Oh, no, no. Of course. I-I wouldn't do it again, I swear".

"Willingly, no. But if you happen to 'explode' again, then what?" she pointed out. "You need to work on your self-control. Discipline your emotions".

"I- Well, yes… I know. I won't use sorcery like that ever again" Castaspella sighed.

"Not just so you don't use magic in such a way again, but in general" the sorceress clarified. "Had you punched him instead, it would still be a logical reason to fire you".

The woman closed her eyes and sighed once more "Yes, you're right".

"Of course".

"Can you stop saying that every time I say you're right?"

"No".

"Mean…"

“Gullible”.

“Hey!”

“At least you look quite cute when you’re angry” Light Spinner told her, smirking again.

“That’s… tha-that’s unfair” she stammered, blushing deeply.

“Now, before I forget…” the sorceress began, putting down her cup of tea. “We have to go to Mystacor tomorrow. Just to see Micah, something happened, although nothing too urgent. So, in any case, let’s make good use of your free day and go check what’s going on”.

“Oh, of course” Castaspella agreed. “I suppose it’s only fair” she added.

“Why?”

“Why not?”

“You said it’s only fair. Regarding what?”

“To-to how he, you know, went with us yesterday and all…”

“Ah, I see. You’re worried” Light Spinner reckoned.

“I-I’m not” she immediately replied, folding her arms and looking away.

“Why are you so ashamed?”

“I am not!”

“Es…”

“Forget it” Castaspella let out, gesturing dismissively with a hand.

“Fine” the sorceress sighed. “Just know there’s nothing wrong with…” she added, but interrupted herself upon seeing the woman’s expression. “Nothing”.

“Can we… talk about something else?” she requested.

“What would you like to talk about?”

“Can you… tell me more about the moons? I read all the material, but I don’t understand how they relate to sorcery” she said.

“Of course” the sorceress let out, smiling softly as she leant back on the chair. “You see, the moons, as natural satellites of Etheria, hold great power over the planet’s forces of nature. Be it the seas, the flora, the planet's inhabitants, or the planet’s magic. Etheria, as I told you, is a living creature, and its magic is accessible to all of us. But only we, by means of sorcery, can actually manipulate a lesser form of magic”.

“While major forms of magic are those of runestones, yes” Castaspella nodded.

“Precisely” she agreed. “Runestones are connected to this planet’s magic in a way similar to that of the moons, and just as those runestones provide great power to the princesses connected to them, the moons provide *us* with an easier control of magic”.

“How?”

“In the same way they influence the tides, they also provide the Whispering Woods with energy vital to plants and animals, right?” she began. Castaspella nodded, and she went on “We’re not that different from the other living beings of this planet, so we, too, are provided with energy. All year round, the moons and the sun provide us with vital energy, but the moons are the ones that enhance our magic”.

“That doesn’t really answer my question of *how* they do that”.

“I must admit, all we know is that they do, and that’s why they are called ‘Moons of Enchantment’. It’s possibly related to how magical powder is produced from lunar crystals, or how the Lunar Lenses help the caster wield the power of the lunar eclipse”.

“That’s… Right. Yeah, I read that”.

“Why are you so curious about the moons all of a sudden?”

“Because I realised I’ve always felt *something* every month and didn’t know what it was… Now I think it was the moons’ aligning” Castaspella explained.

“I see… Makes sense, yes” Light Spinner reckoned.

“And, what do you use the power of the lunar eclipse for?”

Raising an inquisitive brow, Light Spinner replied “Currently? Nothing. Why the sudden interest in *that* particular topic now? I don’t see how that power might interest you”.

“Well, I’ve been thinking about that threatening magic thing up there, and just… Why don’t you use that power to… erm, help? I mean, whatever can be done to stop it, it will surely be more successful with its help, right?”

“Ah… clever. Yes, you’re right. However, what should we use the power for isn’t an easy decision. And it would have to be carefully planned, so we make the most of the few minutes it lasts”.

“Oh, I see…”

“I thought you had no interest in helping Mystacor” the sorceress commented.

“No, well, I… I just think *we* don’t have the power to face that thing. The material you had me study says the power was sealed by angelic beings, meaning they could do it again!”

“How? Es, do you have any idea how many angelic beings are there left in Etheria?” Light Spinner asked, now leaning forward on the table. “Your brother’s wife is the last of them”.

“What!?”

“And, while she *does* have enough power for sure, especially with her connection to her runestone, asking for her help is *out of the question*. Am I clear?”

“O-of course”.

“Good”.

“May I ask why?”

“Es…”

“Bea!”

The sorceress sighed, rolling her eyes, and replied “Because it could take her life. And no one wants the Queen of Bright Moon to sacrifice herself to save an island completely unrelated to her kingdom. Or for anything in that regard”.

“Right, of course. I just didn’t think it would be so difficult…”

“Relax, Es. You were just asking a question” the sorceress chuckled.

“Yeah, but it was a stupid question”.

Later that day, while they cooked dinner, it was time for Light Spinner to be curious.

“May I ask…” she began while pouring two cups of wine. “How long have you known your friends?”

It caught Castaspella by surprise, but she still replied “We-well… Most of them since I was around eighteen. You know, once I started working there. I think only Cyrus knows me from before because he would go to speak with Zo a lot of times, and I was usually there. He’s like an uncle to me”.

“Interesting” the sorceress commented. “What else can you tell me about your friends?”

“Why the sudden interest?”

“I was just thinking that I didn’t have much time to get to know them last night”.

“Oh…” the woman sighed, gladly surprised. With a smile, she went on cooking while telling her “Well, You could say my best friends are Natch and Bri. They were the first ones I met there, the ones who basically showed me the ropes and helped me navigate that world I had only observed from afar until then, and who taught me the basic rules: nothing for free, nothing you don’t like, and never fall in love. Hah! May have forgotten the last one after I met you”.

“And I’m glad you did…”

“Then, uh, well, I had a brief romance with Natch, I won’t lie, but I rather we’re friends, to be honest. She’s nice and all, but I didn’t feel much of a connection in any other sense. And, I have to say, it was kind of a secret because Zo didn’t want any of us to have any kind of romantic relationships” she went on.

“Ah, the thrill of a secret romance…”

“Shut up” Castaspella laughed.

“And?”

“What? Do you want to know if we had sex?”

“Not necessarily. Just tell me what you want to tell me” the sorceress clarified.

“Well, in any case, yes we had, but mostly with the excuse it was a client’s request, which sometimes happens. Many pay to watch, although watching is free, because, in those cases where they want to see something specific, they do have to pay” she explained.

“I see…”

“What else… Um, well, You saw Bri was the bartender, and that’s because they always wanted to have a bar. Their earnings are to open their own place one day” she commented. “As far as I know, they have a place in mind, but it’s too expensive, so they aren’t quite there yet. Maybe in a few years, they are still young”.

“And how did they end up working at the brothel?”

“Like most of us. There was no other place to go, or they had a debt with Zo, or they had been raised at the brothel. All three apply in my case” Castaspella explained, serving the dishes. “In Bri’s case, they were kicked out of their house and Zo found them. In Natch’s case, she got indebted gambling, like Zack and Archie. And those older, like Cyrus, were raised at the brothel and saw Zo as a mother”.

“And how old is Cyrus?”

“Forty… something?”

“Makes sense. According to my sources, that woman opened the brothel about fifty years ago, no less. Yet, somehow, no one knew” Light Spinner reflected as they took their dishes to the table and sat to dine.

“Fifty years!? That’s a lot! A-and if she only came to the surface permanently around two decades ago, how come… Oh, well, I never wondered how Cyrus was raised there because I didn’t know she was from Mystacor. I thought she had always been here…” the woman realised.

“That’s a good question. But, seeing how she had her son a few years before leaving Mystacor, I can only suppose she had her methods, and a lot of help” the sorceress replied. “I could never find out who her partner was; or at least the father of her son”.

“He doesn’t know either, as far as we know”.

“Quite odd, wouldn’t you say?”

“I suppose…” Castaspella sighed, finally starting to eat.

The following morning found them lazying around in bed, occasionally kissing, but mostly hugging each other as they stole a few more minutes of sleep. However, Castaspella eventually got too curious and, while teasing Light Spinner’s split lip, she couldn’t help asking about it.

“Is it… from birth or did you have some accident?”

“Ah, that?” she asked back, letting out half a smile. “You know? To the few people who ever learnt about it, I always told them it was some accident when studying magic” she began. “But, actually, it is… a result of my… father smacking me” she admitted. “I come from a noble family, far from these territories, where they take hierarchy very seriously. My disobedience earned me quite a beating several times” she explained. “So, as soon as I could, I took the chance and fled. I was… twelve, if I recall correctly”.

“Where did you go?”

“I came here” she replied, looking back at Castaspella. “A man found me, an anthropomorphic ram, like your friends Archie and Zack. His name was Norwyn” she went on. “He was from Mystacor and said something about my potential. He took me to the island, taught me sorcery… But also reminded me a lot of my father”.

“Did he ever…”

“No, not at all. They had the same attitudes, behaviours, and ways of thinking. But Norwyn never laid a finger on me” she assured.

“So… That means you… were never in those nurseries you told me about?”

“No, no” she laughed. “I was already old enough to start practising magic. And, as Norwyn was the Head of the Guild- Still is, actually, he decided I could be accepted and trained” she explained. However, right after she frowned angrily and added “Which is why I can’t understand how *you* were rejected. I thought he, of all people, would understand. But he insisted you were too old to be trained now” she continued. “That fool. You’re better than *many* acolytes up there” she sneered.

“Don’t worry about that. Seriously” Castaspella said, trying to calm her down by caressing her hair. “It doesn’t matter what they think…”

“When the time comes, they better accept you and allow you to help, or that island, and perhaps everything under it, will be doomed” Light Spinner let out, warningly.

“Bea… About that…” the woman began. “Why didn’t you tell me earlier that the ancient magic you had me read about is threatening Mystacor?”

“I didn’t want you to feel pressured” she answered, looking up to the ceiling. “It’s true that I want you to help us face that thing, and you may be the key to it. But I couldn’t- I didn’t want to put that kind of pressure on your shoulders” she sighed, closing her eyes.

“Thank you” Castaspella smiled. “I appreciate that” she added.

“You’re not mad at me?” she asked.

“Why would I be?”

“For hiding it from you”.

“No, not at all. I never asked” she reminded her.

“You always say that. You don’t have to justify all my omissions, you know?”

“I mean it” she insisted.

“Es, you’re a blessing” Light Spinner let out, reaching out to caress her cheek.

Meanwhile, back in Mystacor, while Micah slept soundly in his room, the council gathered to discuss the growing threat within the kingdom. Although neither Micah nor Light Spinner were there, they had decided to carry out the meeting regardless. They couldn’t wait forever…

“But every single experiment we conducted has resulted in absolute failure!” a councillor argued. “What’s worse, we even have some corrupted acolytes due to being near that parasitic magic for too long! What are we doing!? We can’t just expect this issue to fix itself!”

“And what exactly do you propose?” the Head Sorcerer asked.

“We must craft a plan. Something that can defeat that corrupting energy for good”.

“Like what?”

“Well, Light Spinner had quite a sound plan…”

“Which we cannot use” Norwyn interrupted. “Do I have to explain to you the perils of her idea?”

“The plan is to seal the energy!”

“To take the power. We can’t risk corruption or even death!”

“Then we only seal the magic without taking its power!”

“The seal from that spell is only temporary, aimed at giving the caster enough time to make themselves stronger. It doesn’t last forever” the Head Sorcerer pointed out. “Without weakening that parasite magic, it will simply break the seal and destroy us all”.

“Then we can use that spell as a basis to craft a better seal, something stronger and permanent” the councillor insisted.

“Anything related to that spell is extremely dangerous. There’s a reason why it’s forbidden” he argued, a hand raised in utter rejection. “We can’t do anything other than protect ourselves with defence magic”.

“Which was *also* an idea suggested by Light Spinner. Don’t you think we should listen to her?”

“The idea of using sorcery to keep everyone safe is a sound plan, albeit insufficient. But it’s a safe option that will give us time to find a better solution” Norwyn replied.

“We don’t have nearly enough capable sorcerers to cover all of Mystacor. How are we supposed to protect everyone when that thing grows beyond control!?”

“Well, There’s… Light Spinner’s little project on the surface” another councillor reminded them. “The woman she found seems… capable enough to perform a defence spell on a large scale, enough to surround all the kingdom”.

“How do you know that?”

“Last time I spoke with Light Spinner, she mentioned teaching that young woman the protection ritual of the Moons of Enchantment. We haven’t performed that ceremony in decades, but that woman may be…”

“How!?” the Head Sorcerer interrupted, disbelieving.

“Well, it’s all theoretical, but she seems to have a natural predisposition for defence magic, which we saw here, may I remind you. And with the eclipse of the three moons, she’d be able to wield enough power to perform the ceremony… On her own”.

“Impossible” Norwyn sighed. “How could that project of hers develop better than we foresaw?” he wondered in a low tone. “In any case, we can’t depend on a single person to protect us all. We need to train as many acolytes as possible before that threat gets out of control”.

“Which we shall continue doing, but I believe it would be better for us to have that young woman’s support” the councillor insisted. “We should do what we didn’t before and invite her to our kingdom”.

“That would be…”

“According to Light Spinner’s investigation, she is native from here, remember? It would simply be restoring her natural right to be part of Mystacor”.

“And what then? What if she can’t make it?”

“If we bring her to Mystacor, supervise the rest of her training, and have her practice to carry out the ceremony, I believe we will be reassured. That is probably our best chance to protect our people”.

“I see…” Norwyn sighed. “In that case, I understand both Light Spinner and the young woman will be coming to Mystacor today due to… the issue with king Micah, so we may speak with her and… invite her to the island” he decided. “If we don’t have anything else to discuss… Meeting dismissed”.

Chapter End Notes

About the fruits the cook offers for the headache, I looked this up and turns out several things help with headaches, as appear in this webpage.

Also, did you notice the contrast between her use of magic in her previous job and her use of magic in the current job? Hah!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

I feel like the second half of this chapter is a bit boring with all the magical performance being repeated, but I swear it's necessary...

Anyways, if you're reading this, thank you for returning once more to my lil fic

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A few hours after breakfast, the women arrived at Mystacor, looking for Micah. However, they were stopped by the acolyte standing guard at the entrance as soon as he saw them.

“Is there anything we can help you with?” Light Spinner calmly asked, towering over him.

“You come to see king Micah, right?”

King!?

Ah, right, Castaspella already knew he was married to a Queen, she should have known… But she hadn’t heard him being called that before, so it took her by surprise.

“Ye-yes” she stammered.

“Then you should speak with the night guard. He was the one to report his state and have you called”.

“Is it that severe?”

“I believe so. Not urgent but… You should check on him” he insisted.

“Well, then, where do we find this… night guard?” the sorceress asked.

“Just wait here, I’ll fetch him” the guard told them before rushing away.

“How can it be severe yet not urgent?” Castaspella wondered.

“Maybe, whatever it was already passed, so no further actions are required. Yet it may have been serious enough that we should be aware of it” Light Spinner considered.

“When were you called about this?”

“Yesterday around midday”.

“Couldn’t we have come yesterday, then?”

“They said it wasn’t urgent, remember? I didn’t see why I should drag you here, tired from work, when we could simply come today on your free day” the sorceress argued.

Before they could keep discussing, the pair of guards arrived, and the women walked into the building with the night guard, discussing what happened two nights before.

“You see. My concern is the state in which the King was brought” he began.

“Brought?”

“Yes. He was completely drunk and couldn’t stand on his own, so some lady brought him. She said he was at a bar, but I suspect it was somewhere else. After all, she was wearing a really short golden dress under her coat” the acolyte continued.

“It’s ‘they’, not ‘her’, I know them” Castaspella corrected him, realising he was talking about Bri.

“Ah, my apologies. I just saw the dress and the hair and assumed they were a woman” the acolyte excused himself.

She then turned to tell Light Spinner “He must have stayed after we left and Bri brought him. They must have been the only one sober enough because they don’t drink when serving at the bar”.

“Ah! That was the bartender!” the acolyte exclaimed. “I-I apologize for presuming again, I really thought… Never mind” he let out, awkward.

He got it all wrong again, but they let him believe it…

“Well, it doesn’t surprise me it was Bri who brought him, you know?” she replied to Castaspella before turning back to the guard. “What surprises me is that he was in such a poor state that you wanted us to come…” Light Spinner told him.

“Well, taking into account that he didn’t wake up yesterday morning… you know? We worried and, having seen the state he arrived in, I thought it would be best if you came to check on him. I was told he woke up around afternoon and, as you can imagine, with a killer headache and even throwing up” the guard explained.

“I *really* need to talk to Bri… I can’t imagine how much he must have drank to be so wasted” Castaspella reflected right as they arrived at the room’s door. They halted, and she asked “Is it here?”

“Yes. We will handle it from now on. Thank you for the report” Light Spinner said.

“It was no problem. Goodbye” he farewelled.

As he walked away, the sorceress turned to Castaspella and asked “Will you come in with me?”

“N-no, no. You go. I’ll wait here” she stammered.

“Suit yourself” she sighed before opening the door. “Knock if you need anything”.

The woman leant back against the wall, little by little slid down, and finally sat on the floor. She’d occasionally sigh as she reflected alone for a good while, and it had been about an hour before Light Spinner finally exited the room. Her expression was serious, and Castaspella couldn’t help but worry.

“Did something happen?” she asked, standing up.

“Even with magic, it’s taking him too long to recover. He’s not built to drink like he did”.

“I’ll have to ask Bri what he drank…”

“And how much”.

“And warn them not to serve him that many drinks next time… If there’s a next time” Castaspella added.

“Hopefully there will be” the sorceress replied, letting out half a smile. “Shall we go?”

“Yes, yes. Let’s” the woman agreed, hooking her arm around Light Spinner’s. “And directly to speak with Bri, they should be free now”.

“As you wish”.

The women made their way back to the entrance in companionable silence, and were about to leave when a voice stopped them.

“Excuse me”.

Light Spinner visibly tensed, which put Castaspella on high alert, and they both slowly turned around to face the inevitable.

“Head Sorcerer” she said, taking a step forward and positioning herself between the woman and the councillors. “And the council, of course. Is there anything you require?”

“Not from you. From her” Norwyn seriously replied.

That made the women even tenser, and they exchanged a worried glance before Castaspella nodded, stepping forward.

“Yes?”

“Young lady, I presume you remember us from the time you came to take the test, correct?”

“O-of course” she stammered.

“I know we rejected you back then, but now we have come to an agreement and wish to invite you to Mystacor, as a citizen” he went on. “That will grant you all the privileges of an

acolyte, and the chance to enter our ranks one day".

"Wha-what?"

"The only condition, however, is that you will have to remain on the island for a whole year before you're allowed back on the surface" he added, much to Castaspella's consternation.

Well, now she knew what to reply.

"No" she let out, indignant. "I-I can't leave everything…"

"What are you saying!? This is your chance!" Light Spinner questioned her, speaking in a low tone and holding her by the shoulders. "You are key to saving Mystacor from that thing, remember? The key to keeping everyone safe".

"Bea, I understand, but I can't" she insisted. "I can't leave my job, my friends, my home… Not now, not ever" she stated. She then looked back at the council and, with a confidence she didn't have before, she told them "I appreciate the invitation, but I will have to turn it down. I can't simply abandon my life on the surface for people I don't know, people who rejected me, to begin with".

"Ah… That's… a shame" Norwyn sighed.

"Now, if you all excuse me, I have to leave" Castaspella said, taking a deep breath. However, before walking away, she told Light Spinner "You don't have to come with me…"

Only then did she leave and, just as she expected, the sorceress remained.

As the council retired, she came back to her senses and immediately rushed after them. They continued walking as she fell in step with them, and began complaining.

"Don't you see how your behaviour is ruining everything!? All of this is your fault for rejecting her! You doomed yourselves that day!" she accused them.

"We had our reasons and the majority decided she wasn't fit for…" Norwyn was replying before she interrupted him.

"Wasn't fit!? For a woman with no training, she was more than fit! But you, fools, refused to see her potential!" she insisted.

"Well, seeing how she refuses to abandon her precious life on the surface, she would have probably rejected the invitation back then too" the Head Sorcerer commented.

"You are all fools!" she finally exclaimed, startling the councillors, then stalked away.

"So?"

"Hmm?"

“How did it go with Bri?” Light Spinner asked as they both had a late lunch.

“Ah, yeah… He drank too much of a weird cocktail Bri made. Something kind of strong, but too sweet for him to notice” she replied. “And, apparently, he was drinking because he couldn’t… cope with reality”.

“What?”

“You know; the life I’ve lived, where I used to work, who my friends are, us being a couple… All of that”.

“Ah… I should have known…”

“He shouldn’t… Ugh… He shouldn’t care so much about that” Castaspella complained.

“He clearly can’t help it” she replied, sipping her cup. “It’s stronger than him”.

“So, what? It’s our fault now!?”

“Of course not” Light Spinner immediately replied. “But that’s exactly why you shouldn’t dwell much on it. We can’t do anything about it, only *he* can keep himself under control”.

“Right…”

They continued to eat in silence for a while before the sorceress spoke up again.

“Listen. About what happened in Mystacor, I have to insist. You can’t just ignore the threat that the parasitic magic represents for everyone…”

“I am not” Castaspella interrupted. “I *am* willing to help, but not if it means I have to abandon everything I know. Why would I want to live up there!? I don’t have anything in Mystacor, and I only know you and Micah from there. So, don’t misunderstand. I want to help, I will, but I refuse to be ‘held captive’ for a year!”

“Es… I don’t want you to be retained there either, but it’s important that you continue your training in Mystacor. Remember we spoke about the Lunar Lenses?” Light Spinner began. “Here you can practice the ritual I’m teaching you all you want, but it won’t be enough. If you don’t get used to adding the power of the eclipse with the help of those lenses, you’ll never be able to do it when the time comes”.

“Why?”

“Because the point of practising is to get used to handling the magical energy with ease, remember?”

“Yes”.

“Then what do you think will happen when you do it for the first time with surplus magical energy?” she questioned her.

Castaspella immediately lowered her head, understanding.

“I’ll be overwhelmed by it”.

“You could even…”

“Don’t say it” the woman interrupted her. “I know”.

“Then, please. Please accept” she begged.

“Look. Leaving everything behind is *not* up for discussion. Out of the question” she insisted.

“And if I convince them of making an exception?”

“I am willing to train there and do as you all say as long as I can keep working and living *here*” Castaspella clarified.

Light Spinner took a deep breath, nodding as she agreed “Then I’ll make it happen. I promise”.

“Thank you” the woman sighed, smiling faintly.

With that, they focused on their lunch and dropped the matter.

Near midnight, however, Castaspella found herself restless. Next to her, Light Spinner was soundly asleep, so she carefully got up from bed, trying not to wake her up. She went to the kitchen, poured herself a glass of wine, and went to stand next to the window, hearing the faint sounds of the street outside.

She had always liked the rustling of leaves that could be heard later at night, the occasional steps from some lonely passer-by… sometimes she’d hear animals even.

Nevertheless, Light Spinner did wake up when she felt the empty space next to her. Yawning but too curious, she sat up, put on her night robes, and went to find Castaspella.

She found her leaning against the window, hair loose and wearing only a short nightie, absent-mindedly swirling the cup in her hand with slow movements, while the street lights coming through the window faintly illuminated her. It was such a sight…

“Es?” she called.

“Hmm? Oh, you’re awake…”

“Did something happen?”

“I’m just… conflicted” she admitted.

“About?”

“What do you think?”

“Of course…”

“Any wise counsel?”

“What do you want to do?”

“I want to help, of course” Castaspella replied.

“But?”

“But I’m… scared. Even if you convince them, even if I can keep my life here and train up there… What if I’m not good enough? What if I can’t handle the power of the eclipse? What if I *can’t* protect everyone as you expect?” she let out, staring into her cup. “I’m just some… lucky girl who happened to…”

“Of course not” Light Spinner interrupted, approaching. She took the cup from her hand and set it down on the table, saying “You’re much more than you give yourself credit for. Haven't I proved that to you already?” she asked, holding her hands. “I believe you have the necessary strength. You may not be the strongest or most skilled one, but you don’t have to be. Just as you are, you’re certainly enough”.

“Thanks for the compliment?” she scoffed, rolling her eyes.

“You don’t need compliments, you need reassurance. Nothing other than being realistic will serve you. I am being honest because *that* is what you require right now” Light Spinner stated.

“I’m not exactly giving up but, just like I told you the day we met: don’t expect much”.

“And just as I said back then: I can, and do, expect a lot”.

Castaspella smiled fondly and took a deep breath before leaning forwards to embrace her. They stayed like that for a long moment until they decided to go back to sleep, and so the woman knocked back her cup.

“Won’t that keep you awake?” the sorceress asked as they returned to the bedroom.

“Maybe… But I needed it” she replied, looking away.

“Try to sleep, alright?”

“I will”.

Meanwhile, up in Mystacor, the council gathered again, this time to discuss alternative solutions. Although he still felt unwell, Micah decided to attend and struggled to pay attention.

“So. The current situation doesn’t look favourable” the Head Sorcerer began. “As I told you before, we can’t depend on a single woman, and we may not be able to get her help at all” he pointed out. “Therefore, I called you all to discuss alternatives”.

“Why don’t we maintain the plan? Perform the ritual to protect the whole island. We could do it ourselves” a councillor proposed.

“The eclipse is upon us, we’d have the opportunity to try it” another one agreed.

“But it’s not like we didn’t try before” a third one reminded them. “We used to have a protective shield raised every month, remember? We had to stop because…”

“Because I’m getting old” Norwyn interrupted. “And none of you have been able to perform the ceremony correctly. So why would it work now?”

“Maybe if we do it together?”

“Or we could- E-excuse us, King Micah, but couldn’t you perform the ritual, maybe?”

“Eh?” he asked, looking up at the councillor addressing him. “No, no. I don’t know the first thing about that…” he denied.

“And there isn’t nearly enough time before the eclipse for him to learn” Norwyn reflected.

“But, you’re a prodigy. I’m sure you’d be able to…”

“I don’t think so” Micah insisted. “I can perform sorcery instinctively, yes, but this is more… complex. It isn’t like casting a spell, I-I don’t even know what it is! I would need years to understand the theory, and we may not have that long” he argued.

“He is right” the Head Sorcerer agreed. “The ceremony is a series of spells aimed at controlling not only the power granted by the eclipse, but also the Lunar Lenses to channel that power. Only then can the protection spell be cast to raise the massive shield we used to have around the island”. Norwyn explained. “If it were possible for anyone to do it, we wouldn’t have this issue to begin with”.

“We should still try” one of the councillors insisted. “We will never know if we don’t try.

Norwyn let out a resigned sigh and said “You want to try? Then I’ll test you. Let’s head to the Lunarium, and I’ll guide you through the preparation for the eclipse. *Just* the handling of the Lunar Lenses. If any of you can properly do it, then you may attempt the ceremony when the moons align in a few days”.

Confidently, the whole council left the room and went directly to the Lunarium. Micah was the last one to arrive, feeling nauseous, and decided to stay at the back, just observing the process.

“I’ll start” a bold councillor decided.

Norwyn agreed with a nod and instructed “First you open the spell casting a simple four-point diamond. You will split it into two and sustain the magical energy evenly between your hands, keeping them about a meter apart”. The councillor drew in light-green the shape as instructed, and split it by separating hands, which glowed brightly in the same colour as the energy accumulated in each of them right after a pattern beamed for a moment between them. “Careful. You’re right-handed, right?” he asked, and the councillor nodded. “That explains why your right hand is channelling more than your left hand.

“O-oh, sorry”.

And so the nervousness started showing. Having problems balancing the energy correctly, the first Lunar Lens that the councillor attempted to move began shaking.

“Step back” Norwyn ordered. “Now, before you break it”.

“So-sorry, Head Sorcerer”.

And that was it for the first attempt.

“Someone else?”

“I’ll try”.

“Same principle” he let out. Without expecting much, he stood a few meters away, observing. “No, no. Balanced. You must… That’s far too much! Step back, right now!” he had to order, as the councillor rushed to try and handle the lenses. “The Lunar Lenses are ancient relics! You cannot manipulate them carelessly! Without them, we will *never* be able to protect ourselves again!” he warned them all. “Listen to my instructions if you want to try, am I clear?”

“Yes, Head Sorcerer” they all replied, almost in unison.

Taking a deep breath, he reluctantly asked “Who’s next?”

“I-I’ll try. I’m ambidextrous, I shouldn’t have a problem with the balance” a councillor shyly said, stepping forward.

“Very well. Let’s see”.

The four-point diamond was cast once again, with an orange trace this time, then it was split between both hands. A pattern different from that of the first councillor blinked a moment, also in orange, and finally they could see how it looked like when the energy was evenly divided.

“Which lens should I move first?”

“The one on your left. Move it up just a meter, and you’ll see the light be reflected with great strength towards the right” Norwyn explained. “With the eclipse, the ray of light shall be even stronger, of course, but at least this will be enough to test how you position the lenses” he added.

“Alright” the councillor nodded, carefully moving the first Lunar Lens with both hands shining in orange. It reached the right position but oscillated between too high and too low, never stopping exactly where it should. “I’m sorry, it’s difficult”.

“It certainly is. But leave it right there, it will serve for now” Norwyn ordered, seeing the ray of light be reflected almost perfectly.

“As you wish. Which one now?”

“The one opposite to the lens you just moved. You must rise it until it reflects the ray towards its left, in a descending line” he instructed. The councillor did as much, once again having issues stopping it at the right position, but eventually managed to reflect the light *almost* perfectly. “That will do for now” the Head Sorcerer sighed. “Now you should lower the lens that is on the right of the first one you moved, to reflect the light into the basin in front of you” he explained.

And so, the third lens was moved little by little until it reached the ray of moonlight. However, due to the malposition of the first two, the reflection missed the basin by a long margin. It was a failure, but that was the closest anyone had got.

“I-I’m sorry” the councillor apologized, ashamed.

“Don't be. It was quite well… I must admit, I’m impressed, even if you have problems moving the Lunar Lenses, at least you handle them with dexterity” he praised. “Anyone else wishes to try? We haven’t got to the actual spell just yet” Norwyn told them.

“Why don’t we have king Micah try at least?”

“I-I don’t know how to balance energy between my hands, I just… cast” he argued.

“Please, just try it” the councillor insisted.

“I- Alright” he sighed. He approached the basin and looked at Norwyn. “How does this work?”

“First draw the shape. From the bottom to the top, and then focus on the energy it summons. When you separate your hands, let each of them channel the same amount of magic. Start with just a bit of energy” he instructed.

“Very well” he sighed again. Carefully, he drew the four-point diamond with skill and then split it with ease, making his hands glow bright pink. A pattern unlike the others shone in front of him for a second, and he tried to focus on the energy accumulating in his hands. It felt like a bit too much…

“Try to move the first lens” Norwyn told him. But as soon as he commanded the Lunar Lens to move up, it shot towards the ceiling and almost crashed against it. “Wait!” the Head Sorcerer exclaimed. “That was close” he sighed, relieved as the lens stopped in time. “I believe you’re channelling too much energy, king Micah”.

“I-I don’t know how to reduce it” he admitted. “I never had to draw less power than what I can” he explained. “I don’t even know what the pattern that appeared in front of me is”.

“That’s a channelling spell, precisely” Norwyn explained, as a suspiration escaped him. “I never thought you would need to learn these things, I won’t lie, which is why most acolytes aren’t taught this particular aspect of magic. So, please, don’t worry”.

“Ah… I should sit to study this” he lamented.

“Allow me to demonstrate” Norwyn decided.

“But, Head Sorcerer, isn’t it dangerous for you?” a councillor asked, worried.

“It would be if the eclipse were today. But with the normal levels of magical energy, I should have no problem” he explained. “Please watch closely” he said.

He traced light-blue lines to form the shape of the four-point diamond, then split it and a pattern with moon shapes blinked in front of him. His hands then glowed in the same light-blue colour, and he stepped closer to the basin. Norwyn then raised his hands and skilfully positioned the first Lunar Lens at the right place. Right after, the second one, reflecting the light beam towards its left in a descending line, and finally, the third lens intercepted it to redirect the ray down to the basin.

“Oh…” everyone let out, surprised.

“Now is when the spell begins. First, the basin will produce light of its own” he explained. “It must be directed towards the fourth lens, which will reflect it to the one in front of it” he went on, demonstrating. The beam bounced between the lenses until the sixth one was reached, which reflected it up to the sky. “The last Lunar Lens casts the light up to the sky, where it will reach the highest point of the shield. If the eclipse were now, a barrier would raise up to that point, surrounding us completely, and concealing us from the outside world” he concluded.

That was enough. The Head Sorcerer lowered his hands, slowly dismissing everything, and the Lunar Lenses returned to their initial positions. The councillors began whispering among themselves and only returned their attention to Norwyn when he cleared his throat.

“Excuse me, Head Sorcerer” Micah called. “Do you really think my sister would be capable of doing this?”

“I don’t know, but your mentor seems confident, and I am willing to see for myself whether she can do it or not” he replied. “From what we saw when she took the test, all the theory of the ritual should be easy enough for her to understand, and it’s clear she’s proficient in this particular kind of magic” he went on. “But it’s true that the complexity of this ceremony is way beyond what any acolyte is commonly taught. I don’t expect anyone to be able to handle it without training” he admitted. “Apparently, Light Spinner *has* been teaching her this ritual, but unless we convince her to come and practice with the Lunar Lenses, we can’t be sure” he concluded.

“Let’s suppose for a moment that she’s capable and that the shield is raised around us. How will that protect us from the threat of that parasitic magic?” Micah then asked, confused.

“That energy may be manifesting here, but it comes from the core of Etheria, that much we have proved. Meaning the shield would sever its connection with the source, weakening it. Little by little, it should withdraw, and even before it’s completely gone, we should be able to banish it” Norwyn explained.

“So that’s why… Right” Micah sighed. “She would give us the chance we need” he said. “That’s why Light Spinner says she’s the key to keeping everyone safe” he realised.

“And I have to agree with that” Norwyn admitted.

Chapter End Notes

The whole sequence of the Lunar Lenses positioning is pretty much a description of what we see Casta do in the show, in the episode *In The Shadows of Mystacor*, which I carefully watched until my eyes hurt cause I wanted to get it right. Also, I realised there are 6 lenses but only 3 are used so like... I improvised a bit.

Also, the part of Casta drinking a cup of wine by the window… I was inspired and drew it:



Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

Ready for more?
Today: Some siblings' solidarity.
~~I think that's the right term, but basically, Micah being a good brother~~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The following day, Castaspella woke up alone in bed. It was quite late in fact, so she had to run to the café without having breakfast, and arrived barely on time. She had absolutely no idea where Light Spinner could be, and she would have never guessed.

The sorceress had left very early. Dressed in her most formal robes once again, she headed directly to Mystacor, omitting breakfast too.

She was seething.

As soon as she arrived, she called for a council meeting, which would finally have all its members for the first time in a long while.

“I suppose you can guess *why* I’ve called for this meeting” she began, her sight fixed on Norwyn, defiant. “More than a year ago I brought Castaspella for you to evaluate, and you decided she wasn’t fit to be a sorceress. Yet I’ve proved she was more than fit, didn’t I? *That* is why you have invited her to live here, isn’t that correct?” she went on, her tone condescending.

“Enough, Light Spinner. State the reason why you called this meeting” the Head Sorcerer ordered, severely, starting to lose his patience.

“I have come to request that you make your offer more flexible to encourage her to accept. You *need* her. We all do. You can’t seriously prefer enforcing ridiculous rules over the safety of everyone on this island!” she explained.

“And how exactly do you expect us to bend the rules?”

“The only thing she wants is to be able to keep her life on the surface, as she told you yesterday. So all you have to do is allow her to come and go freely!” she replied, her tone a bit higher at the end.

“Light Spinner. Rules are rules” Norwyn began. “And in her case in particular…”

“In her case, *what*!?”

“Taking into account her background, we *cannot* allow her the freedom you request. If she’s going to be a citizen of Mystacor, with all the privileges of an acolyte, then we must be sure none of her surface vices come with her” Norwyn explained.

“Surface vices!?” Micah repeated, confused.

“You can’t be serious!” Light Spinner exclaimed. She then turned to look at the sorcerer and accused him “You told them!?”

“I-I didn’t know it wasn’t… I-I had to!” he stammered.

“This is ridiculous!” the sorceress cried out. “None of you have any idea of how ludicrous you can be sometimes! Her background doesn’t matter in any way! It doesn’t affect her capabilities or who she is as a person!” she argued.

“She gave us her reply. She won’t be helping us. Instead of losing time with this, we should focus on finding alternatives” Norwyn stated.

“Because it worked *so well* last night” Micah reproached him.

“You don’t understand! She’s willing to help!” Light Spinner exclaimed, frantic. “But you can’t expect her to abandon everything she knows for a bunch of strangers who rejected her first!” she went on. “You all are *lucky* she’s willing to assist us regardless, so it will be *on you* if the time comes and she isn’t ready!” she insisted. “You *must* grant her permission to finish her training here! Just allow her to keep her work, her home, and her friends! That’s the *only* thing she needs!”

“We can’t simply accommodate to the necessities of each person we *think* may be what we require to confront that thing” Norwyn denied. “We can’t depend on her, or on any individual. We need sound plans, viable plans, and that’s it”.

“Fools! All of you!” Light Spinner finally cried out, furious. “You don’t deserve her help! Or mine! You’re doomed! *Doomed*!” she went on, stalking out of the room.

“I don’t see why it’s so… inconvenient to grant my sister a few permissions…” Micah began, looking back at Norwyn, once the sorceress left the chamber. “Light Spinner is right. Her background doesn’t matter at all! The important thing is that she wants to help, and she’s been training to perform the ritual for the shield! We-we need her!” he said.

“Mystacor has a reputation to keep, king Micah. We can’t simply…”

“So you’re saying my sister isn’t up to Mystacor’s standards!?”

“No. Please, I didn’t mean it like that. But we can’t have someone like her…”

“*Like her*!?”

“Please, king Micah. Listen to me. It’s not an easy decision. All of this is very irregular. There are no established protocols for situations like this one, and we can’t simply give her privileges she hasn’t earned” Norwyn argued.

“It’s not a question of privileges! It’s just common decency! If she’s coming to help us, why deny her the only thing she wants!?” Micah insisted. “Let her come and go. Let her keep her life just as it is!”

“Do you think she’ll be able to balance everything?” Norwyn asked him.

“She’s been doing as much for more than a year now. Whether it’s too much to handle or not, that will be her problem and she’ll find the solution. But if you simply presume… then Light Spinner is right, you’re dooming yourselves”.

Norwyn looked away, hands joined behind his back, and he let out a long sigh.

“I suppose we can consider it. Maybe, we can test her again. If she really has the necessary skills to perform the ritual, then we’ll grant her special permission to come. *But*, it’s not definitive” he finally decided, adding the clarification when he saw Micah’s eyes shine.

“Thank you, Head Sorcerer. Thank you very much” he uttered, trying to keep himself controlled.

And so, as soon as the meeting was dismissed, Micah ran to find Light Spinner to tell her the news.

“Micah, stop running before you fall on your face” she stopped him when they crossed paths in a corridor.

“So-sorry, I was looking for you” he explained. “Norwyn will test Casta again! He will let her demonstrate what she can do, and if her skills are enough for the ritual, they will grant her especial permission!” he told her, excited.

“Let me guess… But it’s not for sure” the sorceress uttered.

“Clearly…”

“Those fools…” she muttered. “It’s better than nothing…” she had to admit.

“Last night the council attempted to perform the ritual, to see if any of them can do it, but no one manages to properly position the Lunar Lenses. I couldn’t even control them delicately enough” he told her, ashamed.

“Let’s just say subtlety was never your forte when it comes to magic” she pointed out, smiling fondly under the veil, especially when he let out an awkward smile that reminded her of when he was just a teen. “Remember: your skills lay somewhere else. And that’s more than fine” she added.

“I-I know… yes” he nodded. “Wha-what will you do now?”

“I’ll wait for the council to tell me what they decided so that I know it’s official, and then I’ll return to the surface, of course” she replied. “In the meantime, however, I want to take a look at the parasitic magic. I haven’t monitored its development in too long”.

“A-alright. Just… be careful” he warned her, briefly grabbing her by the wrist.

When he let go, the sorceress finally walked away, her steps confident and her stance proud as usual.

Back on the surface, Castaspella was focused on practising the ritual, despite having reached a dead end. She had six shards of glass that Light Spinner gave her to practice positioning them as if they were the Lunar Lenses; once again, the woman had them bounce the light coming through the window all the way down into a bowl full of water. When it started glowing, she positioned the remaining three shards to have the light bounce back outside, and that was it.

She could do it, sure. But these were shards of glass. And the light here came into the flat on a diagonal line, not nearly as vertical as the light that goes into the Lunarium through the oculus. Castaspella had studied it all, the correct angles, the time of the day, the exact elevation… Everything. But this was as much as she could practice without the actual Lunar Lenses.

So she was at a dead end.

“Alright, again” she told herself, preparing to manipulate the shards once more. “Focus” she muttered.

However, when she was in the middle of it, she heard some noise on the door and dropped everything as she realised Light Spinner was back.

“Es?” the sorceress called, opening the door.

“Bea! You’re back!” she exclaimed, leaving everything on the table. “Where were you!?”

“Up in Mystacor, of course” she nonchalantly replied, keeping her right hand behind her back.

“Did something happen?”

“I tried to convince those idiots of letting you practice at the island but having the freedom to come and go, yet they refused again” she began. “But, at least, they are willing to test you once more, specifically your skills with the ceremony I taught you, and they may grant you especial permission in that case” she explained. “And I see… you *were* practising just now” the sorceress noticed, tilting her head to the side to take a look at the table. “Is that why all the lights are off?”

“Yeah, I… Well, I know it’s not the same but, with the moonlight coming from the window, I can at least do a simulacrum of the ritual” she admitted.

“While it’s quite ingenious, remember it’s not the same. Don’t get used to the results you manage here”.

“Oh, I know. And that’s the frustrating part. I can’t make any more progress with this alone” she complained. “So, if they *really* let me try up there, we’ll know if I can actually do it” she reflected. Pensive, she added “The material you gave me says the Lunar Lenses are quite heavy, big as my head, and levitate by means of their inner magic. So I presume it will be a bit more difficult to move than these shards, but also easier to keep them in place as I don’t have to keep my focus on not letting them fall”.

“Very clever” Light Spinner recognized. Tilting Castaspella’s head up to look her in the eyes, she told her “That much is true, indeed. And it may be a hindrance, but I believe you can still do it. Wouldn’t you say?”

“I hope I can”.

“I’m sure you can” the sorceress immediately replied. “The eclipse will be in two days, meaning you have until then to prepare for the test” she reminded her. “I will help you practice with heavier objects so that the weight of the Lunar Lenses isn’t a problem. Alright?”

“Thank you”.

“I should be the one thanking you” Light Spinner quickly remarked.

“Why?”

“For trusting me”.

“You trusted in me first”.

“But I had nothing to lose” the sorceress argued.

“I can say the same” Castaspella replied, wrapping her arms around Light Spinner. “What’s this?” she suddenly asked, realising she had been keeping her right hand hidden behind her back. “Bea” she insisted, as the sorceress refused to move her hand. “Show me your hand” the woman ordered, serious.

“Alright… But don’t panic” she finally complied.

Light Spinner ultimately showed her hand from where dark trails ran up towards her elbow, and carefully pulled back the sleeve to let her see the marks ended there and hadn’t escalated further. Surprised, Castaspella brushed her fingers following the lines of corruption, and felt a warm energy pulsating from them.

“Dark magic?”

“Close. It’s corruption from the parasitic magic” she clarified. “Which isn’t very different. But don’t worry, it’s nothing severe. With some healing spells, those will disappear” she assured her. “Would you do me the favour?”

“Of course!” she immediately accepted. “Come, sit down” she told her, finally turning on the lights. Castaspella pulled her chair closer to the sorceress and sat in front of her, attentive to

the instructions. She then followed them perfectly and soon, the marks were all gone. Only a faint trace of them remained, like an old scar. “Are you sure this is enough?” she asked, concerned.

“It is. Feel it, you’ll notice the difference”.

“I- Yes, you’re right, it’s gone…” the woman observed, letting out a relieved smile. “How did it happen?”

“I went to take a look at it. It’s confined in a chamber right under the Lunarium for now. But it has become larger than before. It grew far more than anticipated. I’m afraid we have less than a year before it escapes the containment of the chamber and invades the island from its heart” she admitted.

“Bea… What did you do?”

“I only tried… Ah…” she began, but interrupted herself with a sigh. “I just tried to- I tested a theory” she managed to say. “I told you how that mass of energy is sentient, and I wanted to see what it does to defend itself. Turns out, most kinds of magic won’t hurt it, but umbrakinesis does. So I attacked it with shadows and it attacked me back. It produced something like arms made of shadows that grabbed onto *my* arm and left these marks when I managed to pull back” she explained. “I could feel it offering me power” she then admitted. “It was…”

“Please, don’t” Castaspella interrupted. “Don’t fall for it. It’s trying to corrupt you and make you its caster” she warned her.

“I’m aware” she admitted. “But at least, if it did, I wouldn’t help it escape. On the contrary, I’d use its own power against it” the sorceress chuckled.

“Don’t laugh it off! This is serious!” the woman reproached her, annoyed.

“I know, I know. I’m just trying to lighten the mood” she replied, smiling faintly as she took off the veil. “Come here” she invited, pulling Castaspella onto her lap to kiss her deeply.

“Alright” the woman sighed. “What do I do with this?” she asked, holding between her hands a few crystals.

“Those are Lunar Crystals. They can store knowledge and are sometimes crushed to be used in the casting of powerful spells. *You* will use them to practice. They can also be suspended in mid-air by means of their own inner magic, so they are the closest thing to a Lunar Lens that I can get you for now. The weight is still a problem, but this is better than the shards of glass, I believe” Light Spinner explained. “Now. Let’s see how much you know. Set them on a circle in the same position as the Lunar Lenses in the Lunarium” she instructed.

“But I haven’t been to the Lunarium” Castaspella argued. “I’ve only read about it…”

“From what you've read, how do you think they are located?”

Hesitant, the woman formed a circle with the crystals, which levitated in front of her with a low hum. She corrected the angle and then looked back at the sorceress.

“Something like this?”

“Close enough… Supposing you were more than five meters tall, of course” Light Spinner replied, much to Castaspella’s annoyance.

“Hey!” she complained. “I know they are closer to the Lunarium’s oculus, but it makes no sense to put them near the roof here! The light only comes from the window, how do you expect me to…”

“Es” the sorceress interrupted. “I was just messing with you” she reminded her.

“I know” she huffed.

“Then let’s get back to this. I’ll hold the mirror up here, so the light from the window falls vertically, and you only focus on the crystals, alright?” she told her, keeping a small mirror hovering just above the circle of crystals. “Whenever you’re ready”.

“Alright” she sighed, before drawing the four-point diamond shape to begin. Once the energy was split evenly between her hands, she moved the first crystal and realised it was far easier than with the shards, as they opposed less resistance because of the lack of gravitational pull. “This feels slippier” she muttered, focusing on moving the crystal more carefully.

As the second and third crystals were put in place, the beam of moonlight reached the bowl of water on the table, and it began glowing.

“Perfect” Light Spinner congratulated her. “Now make it bounce back to the mirror. It must be reflected upwards, this time, not diagonally as you usually do” she reminded her.

“Yes, yes, I know” Castaspella assured her, manipulating the fourth crystal. The last three Lunar Crystals were far more difficult to position this time, as the angle wasn’t quite right at first. The sorceress was right, she had to pay attention and reflect the light in the correct direction. “Almost…” she mumbled, fixing the sixth crystal, and finally making the ray bounce up towards the mirror. “There!” she exclaimed, excited.

“Excellent” Light Spinner nodded, pleased. “One step closer. We just need you to practice with something heavier and then you’ll be ready for the test” she stated.

“Something heavier, like what?”

“I don’t know yet. There isn’t something quite like the Lunar Lenses… Perhaps bags full of Lunar Crystals? Nah, ridiculous” she said, thinking aloud. “Or I could keep boulders hovering, so she only moves them? No, no. It wouldn’t do” she went on, looking away, pensive. “What? Just *what*? Think, Beatrix, think!”

“Bea” Castaspella giggled. “It’s alright. We’ll find something… And if we don’t, then I’ll just see how to deal with their weight when I take that famous test, alright?”

“It’s not that simple. They want you to do it on the day of the eclipse, *with* the extra energy it will provide! It’s not a simulacrum, Esmeralda, it’s the real deal, and it can get you killed!” she exclaimed, increasingly agitated. In the end, she was holding Castaspella by the shoulders and staring into her eyes, as if looking for something. Fear? Regret? “Are you sure you want to do this?”

“I am, Bea. I promise” she assured her, gently removing Light Spinner’s hands from her shoulders to hold them tightly. “I’ll be alright, yes? Trust me”.

“I trust you, but I’m… scared…” she finally admitted.

“I can see that…” the woman sighed. “But you taught me well, I’ll be alright”.

“Es… Do you know why they don’t perform this ritual on Mystacor?”

“No”.

“Currently, the only one capable of it is the Head Sorcerer. However, he’s already too old and hasn’t done it in about a decade…”

“Really?”

“Yes”.

“How does age affect this?”

“Basically, he can’t bear the surplus energy from the eclipse. It’s far too much for his body, it would fry him from the inside. And, if you aren’t careful, the same can happen to you” she warned her.

“Bea, be honest with me” Castaspella requested. “Why can’t you do this ritual?”

“Very perceptive. Would you like to guess?” she asked back.

The woman looked away for a moment, searching for the words to say it in the most subtle way possible, and finally said “It’s the extra power. Isn’t it? You… would try to keep it for yourself”.

“That much is correct” she admitted. “And we wouldn’t like what would happen then… So, for everyone’s sake, I decided I would never attempt this ceremony in particular again” she explained.

“Come here…” Castaspella sighed, pulling the sorceress into an embrace.

“*Never* allow me to do any such spells, alright?” she asked her.

Castaspella tiptoed to kiss her on the forehead and nodded “I won’t”.

It was quite early when the women arrived at Mystacor but, up there, everyone seemed to have been awake since long ago. However, there were still some preparations that needed to be done for Castaspella to try and perform the ritual, so the council went into the Lunarium and had the woman wait outside; only Micah remained with her, not wanting to leave her alone.

“Hey! So… How are you feeling? Excited?” he asked, obviously nervous.

“I don’t know… I’m a bit paranoid, if that makes sense” she replied, looking left and right.

“Paranoid? About what?”

“I fear I’ll be, like, jumped any moment now and forced to stay here for who-knows-how-long… I don’t- I don’t remember this place, I don’t know it. I don’t feel safe” she admitted.

“E- Casta…” he called, hesitantly approaching. “No one will jump you and force you to stay, I promise” he first said. Then, he thought better about it, and added “And you can be sure Light Spinner won’t *ever* allow that to happen. She’ll walk through the walls to break you out if necessary”.

That made Castaspella laugh a bit, and it was evident she was finally relaxing a little.

“Thank you”.

“It’s no problem at all. You need to be focused but relaxed before performing the ritual” he replied. “In fact, you should be having a bath at the Steam Grotto before this, but… there’s not enough time until the eclipse” he commented.

“Steam Grotto?” she repeated, surprised.

“Yes! It’s amazing, you’d love it” he assured her. “Hot water, warm steam filling the place, all is calm and relaxation”.

“It actually sounds good” she admitted.

“I swear, it is” he insisted. “If this goes well, and you are granted permission to come and practice it here, you should probably try bathing there before the ceremony so you feel more relaxed and magic flows easily” he recommended.

“I’ll take it into account” she replied, giggling slightly.

“Good”.

A brief, miraculously comfortable, silence settled between them, until Castaspella spoke up again, curious.

“Can I ask you a question?” she began. When he nodded, she went on “I… talked with Bea… Light Spinner, I mean, and I guessed the reason why she doesn’t perform this ritual herself is because she would take the surplus energy from the eclipse for herself instead of…”

“…Instead of simply guiding it to cast the shield. Yes” he interrupted her. “I think it was a decade ago, maybe more, when Norwyn announced he could no longer raise the shield. So, from all of us, she was the only one actually capable of performing it flawlessly. But when the time came, she almost… Ah…” he interrupted himself with a sigh, looking down. “Her speech was like that of a madman. And she had this look in her eyes… I don’t know how to name it other than ‘addiction’. She seemed addicted to the power of the eclipse and didn’t want to release it, which almost killed her because she kept absorbing more and more power from it” he explained. “Had the eclipse lasted a few more minutes…”

“I imagine” Castaspella interrupted. “I understand. It must have been scary”.

“Very” he nodded. “I had never seen her with such an expression. And she spoke of all the good we could do with that power, if only we could… store it. Find a way to permanently wield it, not only for as long as the eclipse lasts” he added. “Which makes sense for her to say because her position in the council has always been questioned, her prowess isn’t recognized, and she can’t bear the idea of being weak…”

“Oh, I know. She gets so angry when vulnerable… Angry at herself. No-not always but, at least in public, right?”

“Yeah, that’s her…” Micah agreed. “So, yeah, it was decided that Mystacor didn’t need the shield that much after all”.

“And now?”

“Well, it would sever the connection from the source of that thing under our feet” he replied. “Eh, I mean, sorry, that wasn’t very clear” he apologized before taking a deep breath. “Under us, inside a large chamber, the parasitic energy you've read about has been growing non-stop. But its source of power is at the core of the planet, which maybe you already knew. The thing is: if we manage to raise the shield, its connection to the core will be severed, so it will stop growing in strength, and instead it’ll start to weaken” he explained a bit more clearly.

“Oh, I see” she let out, pensive. “It may work”.

“You’re not convinced”.

“I only know casting that shield can keep the rest of Etheria safe from this threat. But as for the people within the kingdom… I don’t know. Perhaps if a shield could be raised around the parasitic magic… like, sealing it or at least keeping it from reaching anyone, you know? I don’t think I’m being clear either” she lamented, awkward.

“No, no, I get it. The problem is that it’d be impossible to sustain in time. We would need a seal, a permanent seal, to manage that. A mere shield can only last so long, even one this powerful, and it’s not completely impermeable. That chaotic magic would eventually find a way to sip through and corrupt someone” he insisted.

“We should still consider it, I believe. After all, the only thing it needs is for someone unfortunate enough to be within reach, and that would be all for them. Corruption”.

“And they may be our doom, yes, I know” Micah nodded, letting out a sigh with his eyes closed. “But… I can’t stop thinking about what you mentioned in the café. That the person who becomes its caster may simply… choose not to free it. That could be the solution, but… ugh… Risking corruption is too much” he thought aloud.

“There must be other ways, alright? There is *always* another way” Castaspella reassured him.

The siblings shared a sad smile for a moment before Light Spinner approached, announcing everything was finally ready.

It was now the time.

Castaspella’s expression changed to a resolved look, and she proudly walked into the Lunarium.

Chapter End Notes

So, I mentioned the umbrakinesis.
Did you know it has its own page in the She-Ra wikia? It's very empty, BUT it's there.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Lunar Lenses.

They were *huge*. Leagues away from the glass shards she practised with, and ten times bigger than the Lunar Crystals.

Castaspella walked into the Lunarium in complete awe. The walls were covered in suspended crystals, all the way from the floor to over three meters above the ground. And right in the middle of the ceiling, at the highest point of the dome, there it was: the oculus. It was more impressive to see in person than merely read in books.

Right under it, Castaspella could see the Lunar Lenses, which completely captured her attention. Just as she imagined; a purplish tint, a pattern like a star with several points, all six of them perfectly suspended near the opening through where the light from the outside came through.

“In just a few minutes, the eclipse will begin” Norwyn said, startling the woman as she was too focused on the lenses. “If you need to test whether you can move the Lunar Lenses or not, now is the time. Once the eclipse begins, you can’t lose a second” he warned her.

“Yes, please. I should” she realised. The woman briefly looked at Light Spinner before drawing the four-point diamond to begin her casting, and soon, she was moving one of the Lunar Lenses up. It was easy. It was *easy*. “Huh… I didn’t think…” she muttered, but interrupted herself emboldened. Letting out a smirk, she uttered “Ah, so you’re just nice big shards, aren’t you?”

She dismissed everything and let the lens return to its place, waiting now for the eclipse to begin. She took a deep breath, shook her arms trying to relax herself, and looked back at the Head Sorcerer, waiting for permission.

“You can begin” Norwyn finally said.

And so she started again: first the shape, then split it and balance the energy between her hands. With both glowing in light-blue, she stepped forward confidently, closer to the basin in the middle, and raised her hands as she commanded the first Lunar Lens to move upwards. It stopped right in place and reflected a powerful beam of light from the moons, which Castaspella had the second lens intercept, and then the third one, just as she practised, making the light reflect down into the basin.

Its glow, however, was brighter than that of the water bowl she’d usually use, and it took her aback for a moment. But she didn’t falter. The last three were soon in place too; the energy of the eclipse was now cursing through her veins, invading her body, and she could feel it increase with every second.

It was the time. If everything was correct, now was the time to raise the shield. Except that it wasn't happening…

"Castaspella" Light Spinner called. "That's enough" she ordered.

"Listen to her, young lady" Norwyn seconded.

"I-I can do it…" she uttered, her voice strained.

"You're blocked, you can't" the Head Sorcerer insisted. "You've proved yourself. Just let it go now".

"But…"

"Enough, drop it" Light Spinner ordered again. But Castaspella wouldn't dismiss the spells. Her hands and eyes glowed more intensely as the energy accumulated within her body, and the sorceress grew worried, almost frantic. "It's enough! Let go of it! Esmeralda!"

"You have nothing else to prove!" Norwyn insisted, shocked at her persistence.

But she didn't let go.

If the eclipse hadn't ended…

"This is unacceptable!"

"*You* are unacceptable!"

"I am serious! Do you have any idea…"

"*Idea*!? Are you trying to tell *me* what would have happened!? As if I weren't the one who almost lost her!"

"Light Spinner, it wasn't…"

"If you hadn't put so much pressure on her shoulders, making everything depend on her success, perhaps she wouldn't have pushed herself so far!"

"If you had instructed her correctly…"

"Don't you dare question my teaching!"

"Safety first! That's rule number one!"

"Of course she knows! But she's too… too *nice*! She… she wants to help you all! And obviously refused to fail your test *yet again*! Can't you see!?"

"She only had to demonstrate what she can do!"

“You mean like she did the first time she came here!? Because how well did that go?”

“Light Spinner…”

“Just accept it, old fool! You caused this!”

Castaspella was only half awake when a door slamming shut forced her to open her eyes. The discussion had ended just as her senses returned, letting her see as the sorceress approached the bed, fuming. Only when she was a step away did she realise the woman had woken up.

“Bea?” she called, her voice groggy.

“Es… You’re awake!” she exclaimed, immediately falling to her knees next to her. Cupping her face with both hands, she kissed her face repeatedly and sighed “I was so scared…”

“What happened?”

“That you’re an idiot. That happened” the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes yet smiling fondly. “I told you to step back, to dismiss the spells. Why didn’t you stop the ritual?”

“I almost had it”.

“Es…”

“I could do it…”

“Esmeralda, listen to me” Light Spinner interrupted, severe now. Lowering her voice and moving her face closer to Castaspella's, she told her “It doesn’t matter. Nothing, *ever*, matters more than your *life*. Am I clear?”

“Ye-yeah…” the woman nodded. “Sorry”.

“It’s okay…”

Letting out a long sigh, the sorceress hugged her tightly and caressed her hair, occasionally giving her a kiss or two on top of her head. They stayed like that for a while until Castaspella finally looked a bit further than her own hands.

“Where… am I?”

“Oh, this? It’s my room here in Mystacor. What do you think?”

“Fancy…” she sighed, looking around in awe.

“I would have taken you back to your flat, but… I was afraid you wouldn’t… I-I wasn’t sure what had happened, whether you would wake up… I preferred to stay here in case you needed a healer. But we can leave as soon as you want, alright?” Light Spinner assured her.

“Thank you, Bea. It’s quite alright” she replied, smiling faintly. “What happened while I was out?”

“Mostly, I yelled at Norwyn until I ran out of breath” the sorceress began, smirking. “But, truth is, you passed out right as the eclipse ended. You only experienced… a bit of a sudden loss of power, meaning you went from being overloaded with energy to being completely depleted of it, and that’s why you passed out” she explained, brushing her fingers up Castaspella’s chest. “I imagine it must have felt… anticlimactic”.

“I don’t remember” she admitted.

“Better that way”.

“Why?”

“We wouldn’t want the feeling to interfere with your future attempts, would we?”

“I- You mean, I’ll be allowed to try again?”

“Norwyn is a fool, but not that stupid. You *did* demonstrate you have what’s needed, it would be idiotic to reject you again” Light Spinner assured her. “So you can return to Mystacor whenever you feel like training with the Lunar Lenses”.

“I… That’s… Oh my Stars! So I did it?”

“Of course” the sorceress nodded, proud. “I suggest you try again with the eclipse each month. Eventually, you’ll manage. *But*, be more careful next time. Whatever was blocking you this time, we still don’t know” she warned her.

“I think I know, don’t worry… It won’t happen again” she assured her. “I was scared. I was afraid of failing and… Even if I tried to, I couldn’t get the energy to flow” she explained.

“You’re quite observant” she praised her. She then gave her a kiss on the forehead, and said “Whenever you want, we’ll go have lunch, alright? You must be famished”.

“Quite” Castaspella admitted, giggling.

“Then, just say the word”.

“‘The word’?”

Light Spinner laughed heartily and stood up, offering her hand to help her up.

However, Castaspella pulled her down instead and caught her in a passionate kiss through the veil, which quickly led to touching until they forgot about lunch, more interested in eating each other out.

Nevertheless, just a few hours later, the women were back on the surface world, finally having lunch.

Outside, in Mystacor's gardens, Micah paced back and forth, worried. He could still see it in his head: Castaspella's eyes and hands glowing intensely, her scream right before passing out, and her limp body when the eclipse ended.

"King Micah?" Norwyn's voice called.

"Ah, Head Sorcerer" he noticed, turning around. "Any news? Is she alright?"

"Yes, yes" he replied, hands raised to calm him down. "She just left the island".

"Left?"

"No need to worry, she has fully recovered on her own. You can rest assured" Norwyn insisted.

"What happened back there? Is it really *safe*?" Micah asked, concerned.

"What happened is completely normal. It was her first time interacting with the eclipse" he began. "Normally, people would be too scared and let go of the power. But she held onto it, which is what almost killed her" he then added, looking away.

"*Killed her*!?" he exclaimed, frantic.

"Please, calm down, King Micah" the Head Sorcerer quickly replied, hands raised again like before. "Listen to me: your sister may not have your prowess, she's not a prodigy, but she has managed what no one in the council could. All she needs now is practice" he sentenced. "And that is why we have granted her special permission to study here and come to the Lunarium to practice as much as she needs".

"You… did?"

"Of course".

"Ha! She did it!" he celebrated, excited. "But then…"

"The permission has its limits. She'll be our guest, work under close supervision, and won't be living here" Norwyn clarified, anticipating his words.

"I… see" he sighed. "Thank you, Head Sorcerer" he let out. "Does this mean she will attempt the ceremony again next month?"

"Yes".

"What if the same happens again?"

"It won't. You can trust me. Next time, it will either work, or she will release the energy with no consequences. But it won't get stuck within her again" Norwyn assured him. "In my experience, only the initial shock of the eclipse causes this effect. You have nothing to worry about".

“Alright…”

“Can I help you with anything else?”

“No, no. Thank you, Head Sorcerer” Micah said, smiling politely.

With that, Norwyn walked away, back inside, leaving him alone in the gardens. He took a seat next to a bush and rested his head on his hands, pensive. The images from earlier replayed in his head once more, but he decided to push them away, reminding himself of what the Head Sorcerer had just said.

She would be fine…

During the following month, Castaspella would occasionally go to Mystacor with Light Spinner, and spend a few hours moving the Lunar Lenses into their positions to get used to their particular feeling. Soon, she was ready to try again with the upcoming eclipse.

Expectant, the whole council gathered to witness the ceremony, and couldn’t help but be admired at her confidence. The woman closed her eyes and let out a small smile as she split the energy evenly between her hands. She stepped forward, raised her hands, and it began.

The strong light of the eclipse bounced between the lenses, into the basin, and back to the sky. Castaspella’s movements were gracious even, everyone could see just how used she was to performing this.

And yet, nothing changed.

The eclipse ended, and no shield had been raised. Something went wrong.

“You” the woman called, pointing at the councillor in front of her. “Did you see the pattern that blinked in front of me when I split the energy between my hands?”

“Y-yes?”

“What did it look like?”

“Erm… Moons? For the most part…”

“Crescent? The biggest one”

“No-no, waning”.

“Fuck!” she exclaimed, making the council start whispering in indignation. “I know what I did wrong” she assured, looking at the floor with an angry frown.

Ignoring her swearing, Norwyn approached calmly and asked “Are you sure, young lady?”

“Of course. I’m just an imbecile! I performed the spell as if to *take down* the shield instead of raising it! Ugh!” she complained.

“Calm down” Light Spinner ordered. “At least you know *what* you did wrong and how to do it right” she pointed out. “It’s more than *many* here can achieve”.

“I have to study that particular step again” Castaspella muttered, pacing now.

“And you will. I’m sure next time it will rise” the sorceress sentenced, holding her by the shoulders to stop her. When the woman looked up at her, she added “What do I always say?”

“No point in further dwelling on something I’ve fully understood”.

“So?”

“Yes, yes, I understand what happened and what I have to do. No point in agonizing about this any more…”

“Good girl” she replied, smirking.

“Ugh… Let’s just go for now. I’m hungry…”

And yet, a month later, the ceremony didn’t go much differently.

It was quite the sight: Castaspella’s movements were fluid, it was beautiful to see her move the Lunar Lenses with ease, and how they responded to her commands as if she had been doing it her whole life.

When the eclipse reached its end, there *was* a shield around Mystacor, yes, but not as expected. Having noticed something rise, the entire council stepped out into the gardens to observe the sky. The woman didn’t need more than a glance to realise it was *not* the shield described in her reading material.

“Es…”

“No! I failed again…” she quickly interrupted her. “I have to revise the spell of the shield specifically. I must have missed a detail” she uttered, furious. “I really suck at this…”

“Yes, yes. You’re a bit sloppy… But that’s all. You just require more practice, more study. At least you’re competent enough to recognize your own mistakes and fix them yourself.

“Thanks for the compliment?” Castaspella let out, scoffing and rolling her eyes.

“I don’t understand what happened” a councillor finally said.

Norwyn was about to reply, but the woman spoke before him and explained “See the holes in the shield surrounding us? Those are because a part of the seal was misdrawn”.

“But when did you draw the shield spell?”

“You don’t draw it like other spells” Castaspella quickly replied, laughing. “You have to draw it mentally when the light reaches the basin” she clarified.

“That’s correct” Norwyn nodded, seeing how several councillors turned to look at him. “It’s not exactly easy, meaning this was actually… a great attempt” he admitted, nodding again, in approval this time.

“Yes, but it’s not enough. It’s not enough!”

“Calm down, young lady. You still have time”.

“*Not enough*!”

“Hey, hey. Es” Light Spinner called, in a low tone, making her turn to face her. “There’s no point in getting so frustrated. Just study more that sigil” she told her. “At least this time you did manage to raise the shield. It wasn’t perfect now, but it can be”.

“How!?”

“I’ll help you” she immediately sentenced. “You’re going to draw that spell on the basin until you know it better than your name”.

“Bea, what if I can’t?”

“Again with that?” Light Spinner sighed. “How many times do I have to remind you that you’re performing better than the whole council? Better than your brother even! And he’s a prodigy!”

“Well, it doesn’t feel like I’m doing things right at all” Castaspella insisted.

Feeling out of place, the rest of the council silently retired, leaving the women alone in the gardens. She was looking at the ground, feeling down, and the sorceress couldn’t help but reach out and pull her into a hug.

“I wish I could do more to help you improve faster, but I can’t. You have your own learning times, you should be more patient, Es” Light Spinner told her. “It may not be much, but we do have time still. You’ll be ready in time, I know it” she assured her, caressing her hair slowly with one hand. “Do you trust me?”

“I trust *you*, I don’t trust *myself*. I wish you could do it in my stead” she sighed.

“Es…”

“I know, I know… I just wish… Ah… You understand”.

“I do, yes, but this fatalist behaviour is no good” the sorceress insisted.

“I can’t be optimistic right now…”

“And if I took you to eat?”

“No…”

“And if I cook for you instead?”

“Food isn’t always the solution, you know?”

“It doesn’t have to end with the food…”

“Then tell me more about your plan…” Castaspella requested.

“After lunch, supposing you liked what I prepare you, you can have *me* for dessert” Light Spinner whispered in her ear, making her giggle. “What do you say?”

“You had me when you said you were cooking” Castaspella laughed. “Let’s go”.

The women lay together in bed, naked and sweating, and it was barely six in the afternoon. Lunch had been considerably late, and they spent around three hours in bed, pleasing each other.

But now Castaspella had a little issue which she couldn’t keep silent any more.

“Bea… I want to bind you too” she suddenly said, her sight still on the ceiling.

“Alright?” the sorceress replied, extending the word, slightly confused. “If you want me bound, I can always do it myself according to what you want” she offered.

“It’s not the same…"

“Es, you’re *not* going to use black magic for this”.

“Why can *you* but I can’t?”

“We talked about this. It’s dangerous. I don’t want you to take unnecessary risks” she reminded her.

“But…”

“If you want to bind me so badly, then I rather you use actual ropes for that. With magic, you can control how tight or loose they are, etcetera” the sorceress offered.

Castaspella groaned and closed her eyes.

“Fine, I suppose that would work…” she had to admit, albeit grunting. “But no complaining about marks and whatnot” she added.

“I won’t” the sorceress replied, laughing.

“Any chance tonight?”

“Do you just happen to have ropes lying around?” she asked, confused again, looking back at the woman, who was still looking at the roof.

“I have long pieces of fabric…”

“You’re kidding me…”

“Nope” she replied, finally looking back at Light Spinner.

“Fine then… I suppose it wouldn’t hurt to try” the sorceress accepted. “But tonight. Now, we should take a shower” she decided, pushing herself up.

“Bea…”

“What?”

“I- Thank you… for everything. Since day one” she finally said, hesitant and suddenly shy. While Light Spinner stood up and walked around the bed towards the bathroom, she sat up and added “I know I’ve said it before, but, I am so glad you found me…”

“Up” the sorceress ordered, offering Castaspella her hand to help her stand. “I am glad to have found you too, Es” she said, kissing her forehead. “And that’s completely unrelated to the help you can give us against that thing. I’m just glad to have met you”.

Another couple of months passed, and Castaspella practised the spell for the shield until headaches knocked her out. The months passed by fast, she continued to work, see her friends, and live on the surface, but now she would also spend hours and hours inside the Lunarium, practising with Light Spinner.

With each eclipse, her shield became better and better, yet it wasn’t quite right just yet. They needed it to be perfect, otherwise, that thing may escape Mystacor and endanger the rest of Etheria.

Castaspella couldn’t help thinking about the time Micah told her friends what was happening, how they had pointed out it wasn’t just a threat for Mystacor.

How right they were…

And, to be completely honest with herself, the woman wasn’t doing this for the unknown people of the island. Yes, she wanted to help them, of course, but she was doing this for her people and her world, who would suffer if this single floating island falls.

After another failed attempt, Castaspella returned to her flat with Light Spinner, and both got ready for the evening. Once again, they would be attending Drinking Night at the brothel, but this time, the sorceress had a new dress to wear… Long, sleeved, burgundy, and just tight enough to show her curves; the woman had tailored her the perfect dress for the occasion.

“You really like it?”

“Of course! How wouldn’t I?”

“I’m so glad!” Castaspella celebrated. “I know you don’t really like showing skin, so I presumed you’d like it more with sleeves. And I wasn’t sure at first, but foot-length and turtleneck suit you so well…”

“Are you done drooling?”

“Ha, ha. Very funny” she mocked her back, trying to hide her blush. “I wasn’t- I wasn’t drooling, I’m just… admiring my work!”

“And here I thought you liked my body…”

“Shut up! I do!”

“Oh, I know” the sorceress smirked.

“Are we ready to go?”

“We are…”

“But first… I- Bea, can I- Ne-never mind” Castaspella stammered.

“What is it?”

“Nothing…”

“Es…”

“I…” she began, approaching Light Spinner and placing her hands on her sides. “…Wanted to steal a kiss, if possible” she finally admitted, feeling quite silly.

“What a complicated request” the sorceress mocked her, snickering before removing her veil. “Come here…” she invited, pulling the woman in for a kiss. “Enough with that?”

Castaspella nodded, she let go of her, put her veil back on, and so they left the flat, arm in arm.

Since arriving, the woman had been unable to speak about anything other than the ritual, and how it still evaded her. The last attempt had been close enough, but it was still not *right*! It maddened her…

“Well, well. Enough of that, girl” Bri decided to interrupt. “Tonight you forget about magic and… drink” they stated, placing her glass in front of her. “Deal?”

“Yeah, yeah… Sorry…”

“Don’t apologize, just forget about your duties or whatever and relax, will you?”

“Yes, yes. Of course”.

Light Spinner couldn’t help laughing under her breath but quickly hid it, taking a sip from her wine, carefully behind her veil.

It amused her, yes, but it also made her realise something she hadn’t noticed before: Castaspella’s whole life revolved around that ceremony as of late.

Of course, it was important. People’s lives were at stake, but since when was this entire responsibility all for the woman to bear? How did it reach the point where everything Castaspella thinks and speaks about is that ritual? And she had mentioned *dreaming* of the sigil she has to mentally draw for the shield…

This was getting out of hand.

“Bri is right. Tonight, you just have to relax, alright? Forget about Mystacor, about the parasitic magic, about everything… Tonight is for you and your friends” she told her, imperative.

The woman looked down into her glass with a dark expression and replied “But what if the day comes, and I can’t do it?”

“Es…” she immediately said, with a lower tone. “Don’t speak like that. If you think you will fail, you’re dooming yourself to fail. I’m not saying thinking positive will make it all go perfect, but *you*, Esmeralda, aren’t a defeatist. So I’m not tolerating this behaviour from you” she stated. Then, grabbing her chin gently, she added “Our enemy is powerful, so we make ourselves *stronger*. That’s the only solution, and that's what you are doing. *You* become mightier with each passing eclipse”.

“You think?”

“I know it”.

“But, Bea…”

“No buts… And that’s enough for tonight. Forget about this until tomorrow, alright?”

Castaspella sighed, resigned, and nodded “Alright. I… think I’ll dance a bit, want to join me?”

“If it helps you clear your head, gladly” she accepted, taking her hand.

The women danced for a good while before returning to their stools at the bar, noticeably happier. They had a few more drinks while discussing trivialities with Castaspella’s friends, and it wasn’t long before the woman began yawning.

“Aw, someone’s tired” Natch mocked her. “Don’t tell me you have to work tomorrow…”

“As a matter of fact…”

“Dammit” she complained, pouting. “Don’t leave yet…”

“I really have to…”

“No…”

“Natch…”

“This is bullshit!” she exclaimed, slamming her fist on the bar. “You just came, like, two hours ago?”

“Girl, it was four hours ago…” Bri corrected her.

“Bullshit! It’s so little time!”

“Natch, you’re drunk…” Cyrus told her, trying to calm her down. “If she has to go…”

“Nah, nah! She came here and only spoke about that ritual thing and shit! Now she’s gonna leave already, and we won’t see her for, what? Another month!? Bullshit!” she exclaimed, with the tip of her ears and nose completely red.

“Excuse her, she swears a lot when she gets this drunk” Bri told Light Spinner. Then, they addressed Natch and pointed out “We can always gather before the next Drinking Night, you know? Now let the woman go to sleep!”

“It’s so unfair! She used to be here every day! Now I barely see her!” she complained, now sad, her ears pointing down. “I miss my best friend”.

“Natch…”

“Why did you leave us for those bourgeis from up there? Aren’t we good enough?”

“I didn’t leave you for them!”

“All you talk about is that spell thing for them! A-aren’t we… Don’t we matter any more?”

“Natch, what’s going on?”

“That you abandoned us for them!” she accused her again, this time pointing at her with her index, almost touching her chest. “Don’t you see!?”

Her sight lingered on Light Spinner for a moment before she finally stepped back and left. They all remained speechless until Castaspella yawned again, and the women decided to say their goodbyes.

As they returned to the flat, she couldn’t help apologizing.

“She had too much to drink. I don’t take her words seriously” the sorceress told her.

“But, everything she said…”

“Do you think I didn’t realise it was all out of jealousy? The woman still likes you, it’s obvious… And I’m the ‘bourgie’ you abandoned her for, if we’re being specific”.

“Ah… Please forget it…” Castaspella requested.

“Don’t worry. As I said, I don’t take her words to heart, alright? If anything, I find it quite amusing” she insisted.

“I don’t want to know why…”

“But I will tell you regardless: Those who know me in Mystacor, especially my former pupils, say I abandoned them all for you and the surface…” she laughed.

“Oh, of course they would say that” Castaspella giggled. “I’m sacrilegious or something…”

“For them? Perhaps. But they will soon have to accept you’re their saviour”.

“Don’t say that…”

“It’s a fact”.

“No, not even remotely” the woman denied, yawning again. “I’m just some lucky surface dweller who may or may not be helpful…”

“You will be, Es…”

Chapter End Notes

I must admit I'm having trouble finishing the last chapter so I don't know when I'll post it…
With some luck, I can finish soon
But even my beta-reader is busy lately, as they also post their own fic here…

Anyways, the end shall arrive soon

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> This took too long to finish. Then I realised it has like 2k words more than all the other chapters and it made sense
>
> But well, this needed a worthy ending.
>
> I could have been more evil tho

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Morning found them in bed, comfortably cuddling. The night had been filled with tender touches and soft kisses, and now they felt rested and content. However, it was quite a cold day, and neither Castaspella nor Light Spinner wanted to get up.

“I’m hungry… I need breakfast” the woman mumbled.

“Mhmm… Same”.

“Then get moving”.

“No”.

“Why?”

“It’s warm here” the sorceress argued. “And it’s your free day, there’s no rush”.

While true, Castaspella’s stomach disagreed. It rumbled right at that moment, making her groan.

“I’m starving…”

“So I hear” Light Spinner laughed. However, she only hugged her tighter and complained “Is it *really* necessary?”

“Yeah!”

“Fine…” the sorceress uttered. “But I’m not happy with this”.

Castaspella chuckled as they both pulled away and sat up on the bed, immediately grabbing their robes to put them on, shivering.

“I hate cold mornings…”

“So do I”.

They both walked together into the kitchen and began preparing breakfast, one setting the pot on a ring, while the other used a second burner to toast some bread. A while later, they were sitting at the small table, sharing their breakfast in silence.

Later that day, the women arrived at Mystacor, ready to attempt the ceremony to raise the shield. The eclipse would be right after midday, and Castaspella wanted to take a relaxing bath at the Steam Grotto before it.

Light Spinner accompanied her and, fortunately, they had the whole place for themselves. Peace and quiet. It was perfect.

The woman leant on the sorceress’ shoulder and let out a sigh.

At that, she couldn’t help asking “Something wrong, Es?”

“I just hope this time I can manage it…”

“There’s no rush”.

“Of course there is, Bea” Castaspella countered. “If we don’t break the connection between the mass of energy brewing here and its source of power at the core, it will only grow stronger! And I’m sure that, if we do it too late, it won’t weaken as it should but rather… get angry”.

Light Spinner opened her eyes in surprise and said “I know I told you it’s more likely sentient, but do you really think it could… get angry?”

“Yes”.

“What makes you say that?”

“Between the material I read and your description of it having like several arms… I believe it is… not just sentient but rather like an amalgam of past casters. If it can *look for a person* to unleash its full potential, I can’t help but infer it can also experience the emotions of those that compose it. Like… like some creature, not just mere parasitic magic with no consciousness”.

“It’s… an interesting theory” Light Spinner recognized. “But we can’t know when it will be too late. We can only raise the shield and hope it will weaken with time” she argued. Raising a hand to grab Castaspella’s chin, she tilted her head up to look at her and softly said “Don’t let this burden you now. Just do what you can, focus on the ceremony, and the rest, we’ll face it when the time comes”.

The woman took a deep breath and nodded, then, they kissed for a moment and left the pool, knowing it was time to get dressed and perform the ritual.

The ceremony was carried out as usual. Everything seemed to have been done exactly the same as the times before, so Castaspella didn't expect much.

And yet…

When they walked out into the gardens, the council looked up to see the shield surrounding the island, but in truth, most of them didn't know whether it had worked. Only when they looked back at the Head Sorcerer for answers did they understand.

Norwyn was in shock, and so were Castaspella and Light Spinner.

It had *worked*.

"I did it?"

"You did it".

"She did it…"

The woman squealed and jumped to hug the sorceress, who caught her between her arms and held her firmly.

"Did I or did I not tell you that you could do it?"

"You did, yes, you did" Castaspella admitted, rolling her eyes yet smiling.

"This is amazing" Micah sighed. He looked back right in time to see them kissing, and immediately looked away. Perhaps it would be a better idea to talk with the Head Sorcerer. "What should we do now?" he asked, approaching Norwyn.

He lowered his head, pensive, and replied "Now, we wait".

"What?"

As the Head Sorcerer walked away, Micah followed, demanding answers. The others didn't notice as both walked back inside; the councillors were busy discussing among themselves, and both Castaspella and Light Spinner were solely focused on each other, enjoying the success.

"What now?"

"Now we return home and wait" the sorceress said.

"When will we know if it worked?"

"Soon. I'll return periodically to check on that thing, and we'll see if it's weakening or not".

"And if it isn't?"

“Then we’ll prepare for the worst. But, never think that this was in vain. Restoring our shield is an important achievement. *Your* achievement, Es”.

“Thank you” she replied, smiling fondly.

“Shall we go back to the surface?”

“Yes, please. I’m famished”.

“I expect as much. The day you aren’t hungry after performing the ritual, I’ll be very concerned” Light Spinner admitted.

“Then let’s go” Castaspella answered, giggling.

As soon as they arrived at the flat, however, the woman ran to the bathroom without saying a word.

“Es?”

The sorceress noticed she seemed to be feeling unwell, but she supposed it was related to the exhaustion caused by performing the ceremony. Yet it was clearly something else because, when she arrived in the bathroom, she found Castaspella on the ground in front of the lavatory.

Just what had happened to her!? Was it stress, maybe? Tension? Nervousness as she feared the ritual would fail again? Whatever it was, it had made the woman throw up, so Light Spinner immediately went to prepare something for her.

As she silently offered Castaspella a tall glass half full, she asked, with a groggy voice, “What’s that?”

“It will help you… And get rid of the bad taste in your mouth, of course” the sorceress explained, insisting.

Castaspella sighed, reached for the glass, but halted right before touching it as she felt nauseous again. She held back her strands of loose hair, and leant over the lavatory again to throw up.

It was serious.

She finally managed to drink the glass of whatever Light Spinner was offering her, and carefully stood up with her help.

“What’s happening to me?”

“How would I know?”

“I don’t know… You always know everything”.

“I can only infer… Maybe it’s because you were so nervous about performing the ceremony right that, as you could finally relax, the tension took quite a toll” Light Spinner suggested.

“Shouldn’t I have felt sick *before* the ceremony then?”

“Not necessarily. Some people would be, but in your case, it seems it was the opposite…”

“Well, this sucks…”

“I imagine it does” the sorceress replied, trying not to laugh but finding it quite endearing and amusing. “Now you should rest. I’ll prepare you something to eat, if you can stomach it, of course”.

“Yes, I’m still hungry” Castaspella assured her.

“Can you stand on your own?” she then asked, not wanting to let go of the woman, just in case she were dizzy.

“Yes, yes. Don’t worry. I’m feeling better already” she assured her.

“Then why don’t you have a bath, then lay down in bed, and I’ll have the food ready soon?”

“Sounds great, actually” Castaspella agreed. “Thank you”.

“You’re welcome” Light Spinner replied, kissing her forehead before leaving.

About an hour later, the sorceress entered the room with a tray carrying a pair of steamy dishes.

“Smells good” the woman said with a smile.

“That’s good to know” she replied, setting the tray down. “You know, Es, I’ve been thinking… I’m feeling quite weird myself. It makes me think something has changed in our environment. You may be far more sensitive to it than me, hence why it affected you so much”.

“Do you think the people in Mystacor are feeling the same?”

“Those sensitive enough, yes” she replied. “Even people here at the surface may have felt the shift in the energy”.

“Shift?”

“Something changed the moment that shield was set” the sorceress finally explained.

“Bea, what do you mean?”

“Perhaps you were right” Light Spinner said, looking away and nervously tapping her thumbs together. “That thing up there is angry… We’re feeling its influence”.

“What!?”

“After we finish eating, I’ll go and check on the parasitic magic myself. But, if my inferences are right, this unease it’s causing us shall go way soon, once we’re more used to it” Light Spinner simply said, never looking back at Castaspella.

“Bea, what does that mean?” the woman asked her, reaching for the sorceress’ hands and giving her a concerned look.

“It means that if it is an entity, a sentient entity, we’re in for a difficult fight once it decides to mobilise” she replied.

“Look at me” Castaspella requested. “Please” she insisted, so the sorceress reluctantly complied. “If you’re going to… check on that thing as you said, and if it’s so dangerous as you think, then please promise me you will keep yourself safe”.

“Of course” she assured her, reaching out to caress Castaspella’s cheek. “I’ll only observe it from a safe distance to see if its behaviour has changed. Nothing to worry about” she added.

“Good. You better be back for tea time, alright?”

“Wouldn’t miss it for the world”.

With that said, the women finally sat to eat together in bed, changing the subject of conversation to something less grim.

Light Spinner returned to the flat quite late. For the past few weeks, she had been periodically going to check on the mass of magical energy brewing in Mystacor, and her conclusions only worried her more each day.

She had verified that, just as Castaspella put it, the thing was *angry*. Along with the council, she decided to perform some tests each day, and their discoveries kept the woman awake.

To begin with, it wasn’t weakening. Although its influence no longer made anyone sick, it seemed to have transformed into something worse. Now, that thing was speaking into people’s minds.

Whenever anyone or anything alive went near it, a cacophony of voices would invade their mind. All the animals that the sorcerers allowed near it would raise their ears, then scratch them, and finally run or fly away in absolute fear. All the plants they had set close to it would wither almost immediately, but in a way that the herbalists considered a cry for help. And all the acolytes who volunteered to approach it, even under shields, claimed to have heard those voices, offering them power, enough to do anything they dreamed of.

After these discoveries, the room was put under tight security. No one was allowed inside without express permission from the whole council.

They couldn’t trust people’s greed.

And, curiously enough, the one to point that out was Light Spinner herself, admitting she was talking from experience.

That night, she wondered why she had admitted as much, but a mere look at Castaspella was enough to make her realise she was only thinking about preserving whatever it is that the woman likes in her. Giving in to temptation would mean losing her forever, that much was obvious to her. So, no matter how strong her lust for power may be, her love for Castaspella far surpassed it.

Before a month went by, before the woman had to return to renew the shield, about a dozen poor acolytes had been detained for attempting to break into the room under the Lunarium.

In just a few weeks, the parasitic magic had strengthened its influence so much that it drove people insane even. It would speak inside their heads day and night, first promising power, then degrading them, and finally, threatening their loved ones.

Everyone held within detention spells expressed the same. They needed to get into that room one way or another, or their family, their friends, would suffer.

The council theorized that those acolytes were very influenceable, hence being the only ones to have been driven to madness. But it didn't mean the rest were safe, after all, they didn't know what else the creature could do to their minds.

Creature.

Yes, they had come to the conclusion it was more of a creature and not simply a mass of energy as initially thought. It was an entity, sentient, alive, and its beating heart had to be at the core of the planet.

"Oh, how I wish you could be there!" Castaspella was telling her friends as they enjoyed another Drinking Night. "The ceremony is quite a sight to behold" she added.

"But what about that weird energy thing your brother told us about?" Natch asked. "Isn't it dangerous?"

"As far as I know, it's contained" she replied. However, she immediately thought better about it and admitted "Well, Bea has been going to see that thing every day but hasn't told me much. I-I want to think that, if it were that dangerous, she would have told me".

"Did you ask?" Bri immediately inquired.

"Of course I- Well, I… thought I did…" she began, indignant, but interrupted herself and changed to a more uncertain tone. "Okay, I think I only thought about asking her but then forgot every time…"

“For a whole month?”

“I got distracted!” Castaspella argued.

“In any case, just be careful tomorrow when you go to perform that ceremony again, alright?” Cyrus told her, worried.

“Of course. Don’t worry” she replied, smiling.

Right that moment, Light Spinner returned to the bar from the bathroom and sat next to the woman, asking “What did I miss?”

Castaspella pressed her lips tightly, considering whether to ask or not, and looked back at Zack, who was gesturing at her to do it.

“Alright, I- We were talking, and I realised I never asked you what is going on with the parasitic energy up there” she finally let out.

“I hoped you wouldn’t ask” the sorceress admitted, holding her veil to carefully sip her wine for a moment. “I didn’t want to tell you, but I suppose it’s better if you know before going to Mystacor tomorrow” she sighed. “To begin with, we’ve come to the conclusion that it’s actually a creature, not just… energy. You were right” she began. “Just as you said, it’s possibly an amalgam of previous casters, and it can even… speak” she went on, shocking Castaspella and her friends. They remained speechless as she concluded “It has the ability to speak into our minds, and it has driven some acolytes insane. We hardly have any idea what we're facing”.

“Bea, that’s… How can it be?”

“I don’t know… But now I see how it can procure itself a caster to be freed”.

“How?”

Light Spinner took another sip of wine and set the cup down before explaining “I thought it would try to grab whoever is closer, on instinct, and that its corruption would turn them into the caster with the ability to set it free. But it’s far worse”.

“How can it be worse?”

“It’s not just a source of power. It’s an intelligent entity: it offers its power to the caster, offers to fulfil their dreams; if that doesn't work, it humiliates them and threatens their loved ones, all to push them into freeing it” she clarified. “The caster may have a choice but, if it’s someone easy to manipulate…”

“Then we make sure it can’t get a caster” Castaspella interrupted.

“It’s quite difficult, Es. The acolytes who have gone insane over it were… aggressive”.

“Then what can we do?”

Light Spinner looked down at her cup and finally admitted “I don’t know”.

“Bu-but it’s contained, right? It can’t break free on its own, right?” Archie asked, pale.

“On its own, no. But the possibility of someone falling into temptation and managing to get into the room is still there…” she replied, pessimistic.

“Can… you banish it?” Cyrus asked, calling the sorceress’ attention. “I remember Zo talking about creature banishment… She’d sometimes mumble something about dark creatures, or… No, dark magic creatures” he explained. “You may not remember, Casta, but once I walked into her trying to teach you how to banish creatures” he added with half a smile.

“I don’t remember, no”.

“She gave up on that idea before you turned ten, so I didn’t expect you to remember” he clarified.

“It isn’t impossible, but with its strength and influence, I doubt we can banish it…” Light Spinner sighed, shaking her head.

“Can we try?”

“Es…”

“I know, I know. It’s dangerous” Castaspella interrupted her, gesturing with her hands for her to stop. “But if we don’t try, and people get hurt… we’ll regret it the rest of our lives” she insisted.

The sorceress looked back at her with a tired expression and asked “Are you sure you want to… take such a risk for people you don’t know?”

“It’s not just for Mystacor, it’s for them too” she replied, indicating her friends. “If we don't get rid of that thing, it will only become worse. As you said, the possibility is there. If something happens and that thing escapes, everyone will be at risk. And *that* is what I want to avoid”.

“I see” the sorceress let out, smiling under the veil. “Then… I suppose we have to try” she sighed. “Tomorrow, you focus on the ceremony, and I’ll deal with the council”.

“Yes, please. We’ll need all the help we can get”.

The following day, Castaspella took the day off from work as she had to go renovate the shield around Mystacor, and while she went to have a relaxing bath at the steam grotto, Light Spinner had the council gather.

She explained what Castaspella suggested, about banishing that parasitic entity, and how they would have better chances if they all attempted it.

“But it’s just a slim chance. We can’t take such a risk!” a councillor argued.

“If we perform a banishing spell, we would be open to attacks from that thing” another one pointed out.

“While attempting to banish that chaotic magic sounds plausible, it is far too risky as we’d also be vulnerable to what you yourself are telling us is a sentient being” Norwyn told Light Spinner, with a serious tone. “And seeing how it’s only a possibility, I don’t think it’s worth the risk. We have no warranties; we could all be decimated in an instant. We’d be so exposed that it would be like handing ourselves in a silver plate. Mystacor would fall immediately” he argued.

“Mystacor will fall regardless if we do nothing!”

“Light Spinner, think for a moment” the Head Sorcerer pleaded. “The risk is far too great!”

“So what exactly is your plan!?” she inquired, exasperated.

“We resist. We stick to defensive spells if that thing were to attack” he replied. “As far as we know, that thing only reacts, meaning that if we don’t engage it, it won’t retaliate” he added.

“We don’t know that for sure! Up to now, it has done nothing other than the mental manipulation thing, but it is *sentient*! It is *smart*! It might simply be waiting for the right moment to strike!”

“All the more reasons not to provoke it!” he retorted, getting irritated too. “When will you start thinking about the lives that are at stake!?”

“I *am* thinking about that! That’s the only reason why I’m proposing this plan!”

“You are neglecting the risks, as usual, and remain blind to the reality we’re facing, Light Spinner” he countered.

“Enough! I’m not tolerating any more of this!” she finally exploded. “If you all, bunch of cowards, won’t do anything about it, then don’t start crying when everything goes west!” she exclaimed, glaring at Norwyn. “I was a fool for thinking you’d have enough guts to do what’s necessary to protect your people!” she added, stalking out of the room.

Finally, the ceremony was carried out as usual, under the supervision of the council, except for Light Spinner who decided to wait outside, still offended at Norwyn and the rest.

Once it was done, everyone trusted the shield was flawless and didn’t even check on it, except for Castaspella, who couldn’t help going to the gardens to see for herself. Light Spinner followed her silently and sat down on a bench nearby.

“Ah… Good, good. It worked” the woman sighed. She then turned to see Light Spinner at the bench and decided to join her. “Why did you stay outside the Lunarium today?”

“I’m sorry, Es. I couldn’t convince them…”

“Oh, Bea” she let out, realising her defeated expression was due to that. She leant on her and assured her “It’s alright, you did what you could. They are just… stubborn”.

“What do you want to do now?”

“I suppose we can only wait; be ready for when that thing plays up”.

“You say it as if it were a child about to do mischief…”

“Maybe we should consider that’s exactly what that ‘creature’ is” Castaspella explained.

“An interesting opinion…”

“A good interesting?”

“It’s insightful” Light Spinner told her.

“Bea, what do you think we should do?”

“Our best, Es. We don’t have another choice” she let out, noticeably resigned. “Without enough help, we can’t banish that thing”.

“Correct me if I’m wrong…” Castaspella began, thoughtful. “Because of the shield, this thing can’t escape the island, right?”

“Right”.

“Then, what about evacuating Mystacor?” she proposed.

“While a sensible option, I doubt anyone would be willing” the sorceress countered.

“Do they really hate the surface that much?” the woman asked, in disbelief. As Light Spinner kept silent, she took it as a ‘yes’. “Fine, but… if the worst happens, they won’t have a choice either” she pointed out.

“It’s the logical reaction. I know the council will initiate an evacuation when that thing gets out of control” Light Spinner assured her. “But you might want to suggest it to them before we leave” she laughed.

“You really don’t trust them” Castaspella noted.

“I don’t trust their judgement. They are too short-sighted. Always have been…”

“Then I suppose we should tell them as you said” she replied, standing up. “Shall we go?” she asked, offering her hand for the sorceress to take.

“I suppose” she sighed, standing up with her help.

The women finally decided to leave the island after discussing the evacuation plan with Norwyn and the rest of the council. As they walked down the halls to leave the building, a sudden commotion caught their attention, and they stopped in their tracks.

“What’s that?”

“It’s… Isn’t it coming from the…” Light Spinner wondered, trailing off as she realised. “Oh, no. Not now!” she exclaimed, rushing towards the commotion.

“Wait!”

The woman ran after the sorceress to catch up, and soon understood what was happening.

Someone dressed like the acolytes was madly slamming their fists against the door of a chamber. At first, it confused Castaspella, until she connected the dots and realised where they were.

“No, no, no, no! Stop!” she yelled, running faster to catch them before they managed to open the doors. “Stop!” she insisted, trying to restrain them.

“Don’t let them go!” Light Spinner ordered as she knelt to check on the passed-out acolytes that were guarding the door. However, as soon as she was done checking their pulse, she clutched her head as a voice rang inside it. “What?” she muttered. Slowly, she stood up, staring at the closed doors, and completely ignoring Castaspella’s struggle to hold the acolyte back.

“Bea! Help me!”

“What?” she muttered again, barely moving her head but unable to look away from the doors. “No…” she then let out, frowning. “How?”

“Bea!”

“Es…”

The sorceress finally turned around to see what was happening and used a quick spell to knock the acolyte unconscious. The woman immediately took a deep breath and carefully let them fall to the floor.

“What was that!?” Castaspella reproached her, but Light Spinner had turned to stare at the doors again. “Bea, are you listening to me!?”

“There is no way… I’m allowing you…” the sorceress began saying under her breath, as her right hand pressed against one of the doors. “To hurt her” she concluded, frowning angrily as she pushed and opened the chamber.

“Wait!” the woman exclaimed, reaching for Light Spinner when she realised what she was doing. An alarm was triggered by the spells on the entrance, and loud sirens filled the air in an instant. However, they were so completely enthralled by the thing revolving in the middle of the room that they paid the alarms no attention. “Bea, what… is that?”

“I’ve never seen it so active before” the sorceress admitted. “It wants to hurt you, but I won’t allow it” she stated, determined.

Before Castaspella could reply, Norwyn arrived running, followed by three councillors. They stopped as soon as they saw the room open, and paled in fear. The Head Sorcerer forced himself to react and fixed the woman with his eyes, silently demanding an explanation.

“It’s not…” ‘what it looks like’ she was going to say, but Light Spinner moving behind her made her interrupt herself to stop the sorceress. “What are you doing!?”

“Light Spinner! Don’t you take another step!” Norwyn ordered, his voice louder than the alarms.

“I know what I’m doing” she sentenced, slightly turning her head back but keeping her back towards him. “Don’t try to stop me”.

“Beatrix! Stop!” Castaspella insisted, grabbing her left arm with both hands. “Stay back and I’ll put up a shield to keep us safe” she told her.

“Don’t be ridiculous. For how long do you think you can maintain it?”

“With your help, enough to seal this chamber again!” she assured her, gripping her arm tighter.

But the sorceress only scoffed and dared her “Go ahead. Try it”.

The woman sighed, let go of her, albeit reluctantly, and closed her eyes for a single second to prepare.

Just a moment.

Yet, taking the chance before she could raise the shield, Light Spinner advanced towards the chaotic magic. Castaspella immediately rushed after and grabbed her by the wrist this time. The sorceress turned, ready to argue again, but the woman spoke first.

“Please, don’t do this! You can’t- You don’t have to do this!”

“It’s the only way. Just trust me, Esmeralda”.

“I trust you, but I'm afraid… I can’t lose you!”

“And you won’t” Light Spinner assured her, holding Castaspella’s hands between hers. “I will return to you… I love you”.

“You…” the woman sighed, shocked. “You said it”.

“Because it’s true. I should have said it before”.

“But you’re too stubborn” Castaspella weakly laughed, with tears escaping her eyes.

“Now, let me go” the sorceress requested, giving her a kiss through the veil.

Little by little, the woman released her hands and Light Spinner took a step back before turning to leave.

“You *better* return to me!” Castaspella exclaimed, right as the sorceress cast some spell, advancing towards the parasitic magic that kept revolving in the middle of the room.

The woman finally raised a shield, protecting herself and everyone behind her, yet her sight remained on Light Spinner as she got increasingly worried.

At first, nothing happened, the magic wasn’t reacting to her approach, but in an instant, it rose and fully surrounded the sorceress with a dozen black arms. Out of instinct, Castaspella extended a hand forwards and raised a shield around Light Spinner, but it was late.

Mystacor began shaking.

The alarms had made everyone panic, and the council had split to handle the evacuation, as they had discussed less than an hour before. The councillors had no idea what exactly was happening, all they knew was that they had to take everyone to safety.

King Micah’s duty was to do the same, but he couldn’t stop thinking that he hadn’t seen his sister evacuate, and too little time had passed since she went to speak with the council.

So she could only be in one place.

He knew he had to help everyone by overlooking the evacuation, but he simply *couldn’t*. Unable to stay there knowing nothing, he teleported to the halls under the Lunarium and was shocked to find the doors open. A powerful shield had been cast, and with the help of the Head Sorcerer and some councillors, Castaspella held it in place.

He had arrived just in time to see the creature spawn far too many arms and envelope Light Spinner, despite his sister’s efforts to protect her.

“No!” he screamed, rushing forwards. “Light Spinner!” he called out, slamming the shield. “Let me through!”

“We can’t” Castaspella immediately replied, her sight fixed on the black cocoon that formed around the sorceress.

“We can’t leave her alone!”

“Micah! Listen to me!” his sister yelled, looking back at him with tears streaming down her face. “If I take down this shield, if that thing hurts us, what she did will have been for nothing!”

“Then what are we supposed to do!? Watch as that thing…” he was saying, frenetic, until some movement caught his attention. “What!?”

The siblings stared in shock as the black arms receded and let Light Spinner stand up. She never looked back at them, she didn't say a word, and when she rose her left arm towards the creature, Castaspella recognized the scars she had once healed.

"It's corruption" she uttered. "She… became its caster" she realised.

"No… She wouldn't betray us" Micah denied, shaking his head stubbornly.

"Bea…" she sighed, as a last tear fell down. Swallowing through the lump in her throat, she finally ordered "Close the doors".

Half of Mystacor's citizens had already left by the time the island stopped shaking. Even though the sirens blaring died down with the tremors, the councillors decided to continue evacuating. Just in case. After all, no one knew what was happening, whether it was a good thing or just the calm before the storm.

Outside the chamber, laying against the closed doors, the siblings couldn't stand the sudden silence that surrounded them.

"Why?" Micah sighed.

"Bea" Castaspella uttered.

"I don't get it…"

"You promised to return" the woman let out, as if speaking directly to the sorceress.

"Youngsters" Norwyn called.

"Don't" Castaspella quickly interrupted him, struggling to stand up. "If you say something about having saved the kingdom and whatnot, I swear I…"

"You will *what*, exactly?" the Head Sorcerer defied her. "If you'd rather I don't say it, then I won't. But what's done is done" he pointed out.

"Why didn't you listen to her!?" the woman finally managed to say. "With your help, we could have banished that creature!"

"The risks were too high".

"You always speak about risks as if there were a way to avoid them in this scenario! Don't you see? Every option entailed risks! A banishment ritual could have worked, but you didn't even let us *try*!" she reproached him.

"Listen, young lady" he began, stepping closer, and keeping his tone calm despite Castaspella's anger. "I am deeply sorry for your loss, but her sacrifice saved countless lives" he remarked. "She made a decision, she refused to be stopped" he reminded her.

“She had no other choice because you turned down all her alternative plans!” the woman insisted.

“I see we won’t be able to reach an agreement” he sighed. “But I truly am sorry”.

As the sorcerer turned around to leave, Castaspella lowered her head, closed her hands tightly in fists, and frowned, feeling about to explode. Yet before her rage made her do something stupid, the doors behind her began shaking with powerful blows from the inside.

“No way” she uttered, shocked for a moment before being joined by her brother, who stood up from the door, startled. “I’m so sorry” she sobbed, reinforcing the spells that kept the doors closed.

Right at that moment, the banging stopped, the doors stood in place, and there was silence again. Everyone held their breaths, expectant, and stared at the door, as if it could burst open any moment.

“You don’t disappoint” a voice suddenly said, drawing everyone’s attention to the corridor in front of the chamber. When they all turned to look, she only smirked under the tattered veil and added “Good to know those feelings of yours won’t drown your good judgement”.

Castaspella could hear her heart beating in her ears.

It couldn’t be true. Yet there she was, in front of her eyes.

As she took a step forwards, both her brother and the Head Sorcerer reached out and stopped her.

“Let go” she ordered.

“She has been corrupted. You shouldn’t…”

“She was corrupted to save us all! So don’t tell me what to do now, Head Sorcerer” she interrupted him. Glancing back at the sorceress, she stated “I know what I’m doing”.

“Let her” Micah sighed.

Resigned, Norwyn released the woman, and Castaspella approached warily.

“What did you do?” she gently asked.

“What I promised” the sorceress simply replied.

“Bea, why?”

“It was the only way” she replied, not daring to reach out and cup her face as she wanted.

“But why risk it!? We know how you get when it comes to power!” Castaspella pointed out, about to cry again.

And she was right, except for one thing that made the sorceress smirk.

“Good thing I had a greater desire other than the power it offered me”.

“So, you-you banished it?” the woman asked, daring to step closer.

“Just as you suspected, as its caster, I could command it to leave. And so I did” she explained. “I had to renounce all the power it offered me, of course, but what would be the point of all that might if it meant losing you?”

“Bea…” she sobbed, putting aside her wariness to hug her tightly. “I can’t believe you’re alive” she said. “You feel… smaller… Like-like it consumed you”.

“I suppose it did” she admitted. “But I promised to return to you, didn’t I?”

Silently watching the scene, Norwyn remained pensive, Micah was too shocked to move or speak, and the councillors kept whispering among themselves.

“Li-Light Spinner?” one dared call, forced by the others.

“Do *not* call me that any more” she immediately replied. She then glared at the Head Sorcerer before saying “After all, I presume I’m banished from here, am I not?”

“What?”

“Unfortunately, yes” Norwyn admitted. “Rules are rules”.

“What an ungrateful bunch…” Castaspella complained. “She did this for you all! You never deserved her help!”

“Forget it, Es. Remember what you said: the rest of Etheria was in danger too. Your world, your friends, they were in danger. We did this to save *them*”.

“You didn’t have to” she replied. “Now look at those scars… It must hurt a lot”.

“Quite”.

“Then let’s go home, so I can treat them” Castaspella insisted. “We should teleport directly there”.

“I can only use black magic now” she pointed out.

“I’ll do it”.

“Please…” Micah interrupted. “Allow me…” he requested. Castaspella held his stare for a moment but finally accepted as he insisted “She’ll always be my Master”.

Months passed.

King Micah finally returned to Bright Moon, to his wife and his daughter, having quit the council in exchange for a relaxed life with his family. He would occasionally teleport back to see his sister, sometimes to invite her to have dinner in Bright Moon with them, and every once in a while, he'd also join Castaspella and her friends for Drinking Night.

Castaspella, despite everything, agreed to keep renewing the shield around Mystacor every month, in exchange for a single favour: they had to leave the sorceress in peace. No matter what their rules about black magic said, they would let her live, and she would stay out of their way too.

And speaking of her…

She abandoned almost everything. Her name, her status, her role as a tutor, her belongings back on the island, and her old robes, which were quite destroyed regardless. Instead, she adopted a new name she heard from her spies, who still reported everything that happened up in Mystacor including the prevailing narrative of what happened that day. The story had been twisted until everyone believed that she, Light Spinner, had died that day in the hands of some dark sorceress whom they called 'Shadow Weaver'.

Now, dressed in the long, sleeved burgundy dress that covered all her scars, and wearing a curious red mask instead of her veil, the sorceress became the object of scary tales…

But none of them could keep Castaspella away from her.

The woman remained by her side, never let go, and became the only light onto which Shadow Weaver would hold.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you all liked this, and if you are disappointed, I'm so sorry.
I'm writing this for fun, alright? It was an idea, a concept, developed into a story.

That's all.

Thank you very much for reading.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!